FEMALE POLITICAL INCLUSION IN LEGISLATIVE ELECTIVE POSITIONS IN SOUTH WESTERN NIGERIA (2015-2023)

This questionnaire is part of a Ph.D. research study in the Gender Studies Programme of the Institute of African Studies, University of Ibadan. The study investigates the context of female political inclusion in legislative elective positions in South Western Nigeria between 2015 and 2023.

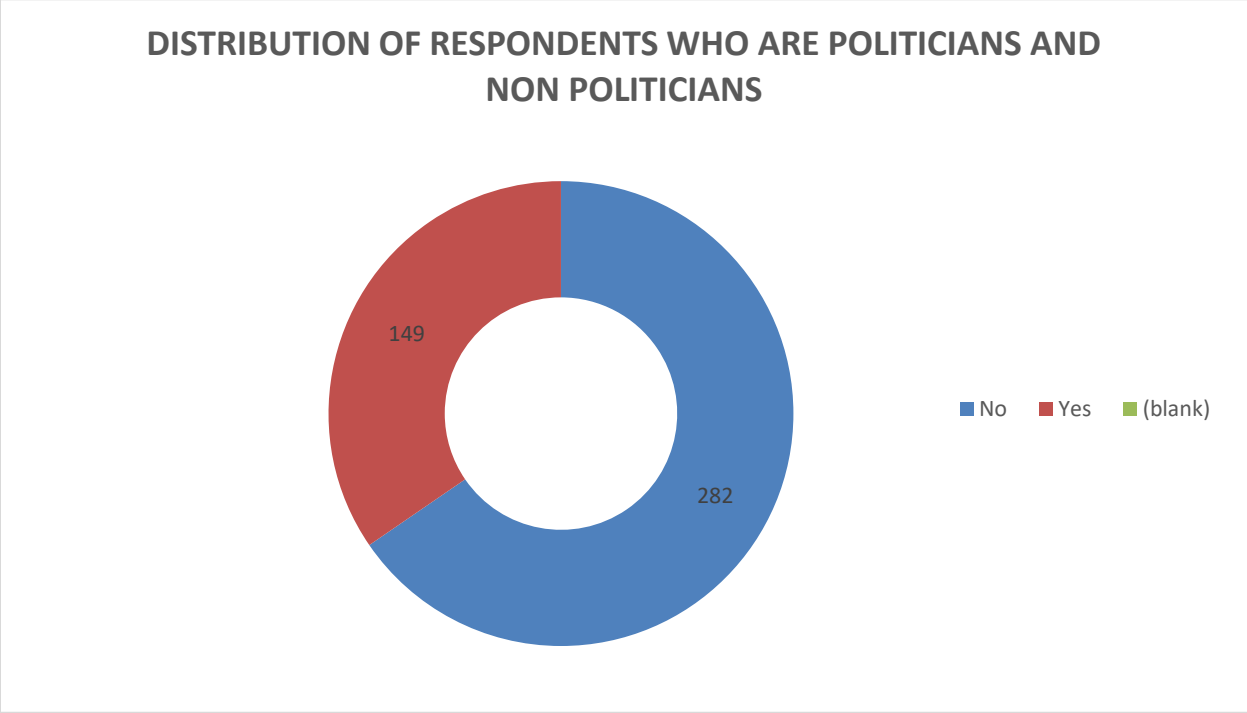
The dataset comprises responses collected through a structured questionnaire administered between June 2025 and October 2025. The survey captured data from a defined population relevant to the study objectives and generated a comprehensive set of responses for analysis.

The questionnaire included a combination of multiple-choice questions**,** Likert-scale items**,** and yes/no questions, and open-ended responses, allowing for both quantitative and qualitative analysis. This mixed-question design enabled the measurement of respondent perceptions, experiences, and opinions, while also providing space for detailed, narrative insights.

A total of 431 responses were recorded and used for the analysis.

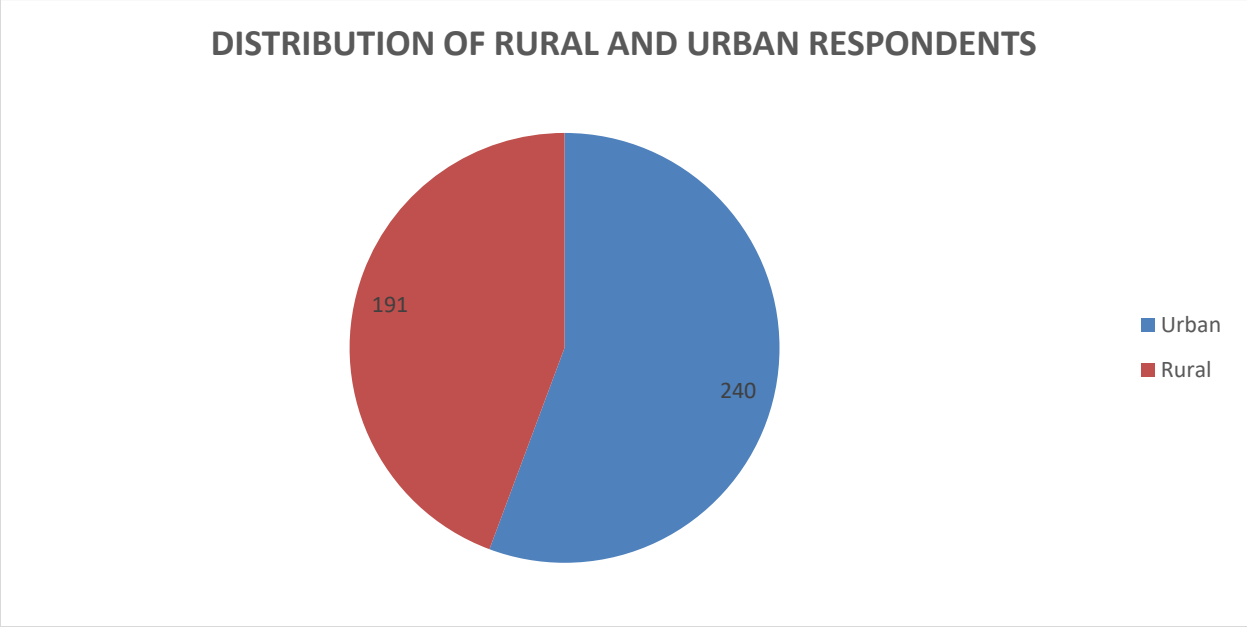
Of the 431 respondents, 23.7% were from Oyo State (102 respondents), 22.7% from Lagos State (98 respondents), 15.08% from Ekiti State (65 respondents), and 13.9% from Ondo State (60 respondents). Ogun State accounted for 12.76% of responses (55 respondents), while Osun State contributed 11.83% (51 respondents).

Politicians and Non-Politicians



Out of the 431 respondents, 282 individuals (65.4%) indicated that they are not politicians, while the remaining 149 respondents (34.6%) identified as politicians. This distribution suggests that the perspectives captured in the study are predominantly from non-politicians.

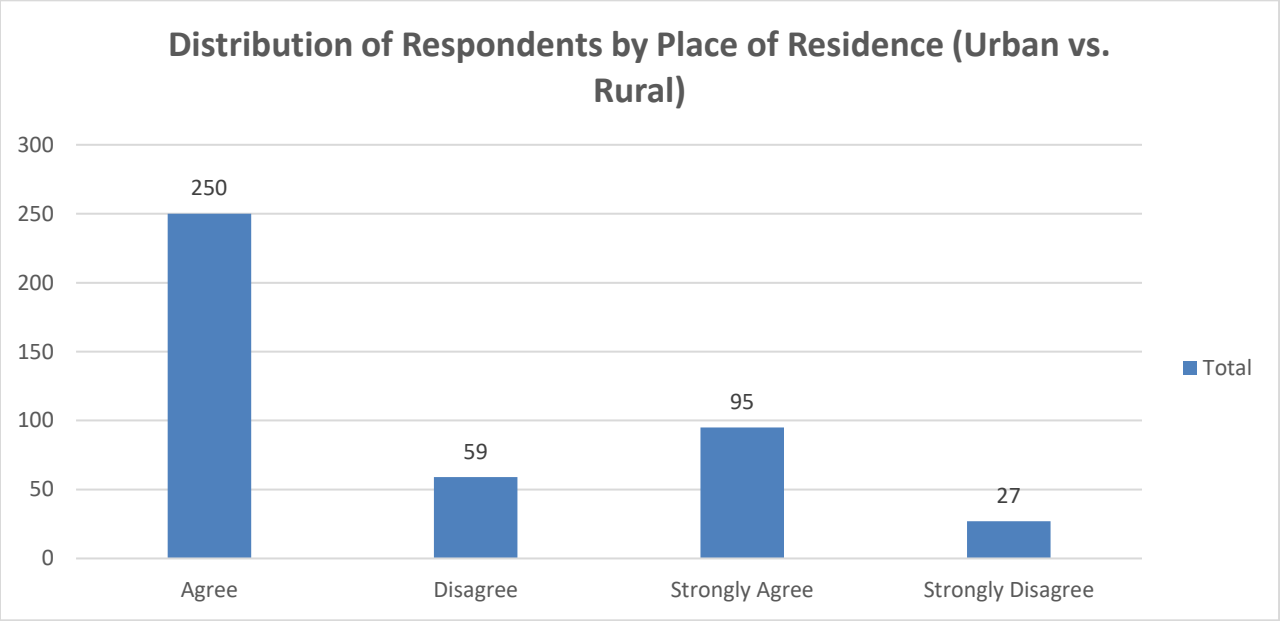
Urban and Rural Respondents



Out of the 431 respondents, 240 (55.7%) were from urban areas, while the remaining 191 respondents (44.3%) were from rural areas. This distribution indicates a slightly higher representation of urban respondents in the study.

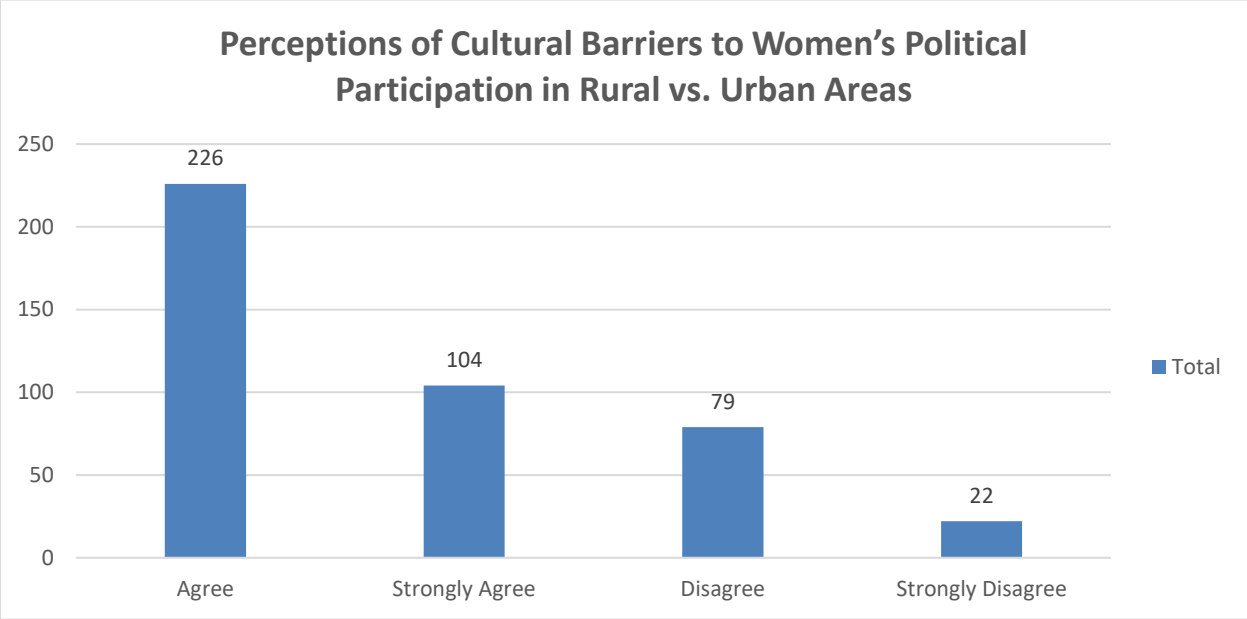
Experiences of female's in Political Participation in Urban versus Rural areas

Women in Urban areas have more opportunities to participate in politics than those in rural areas



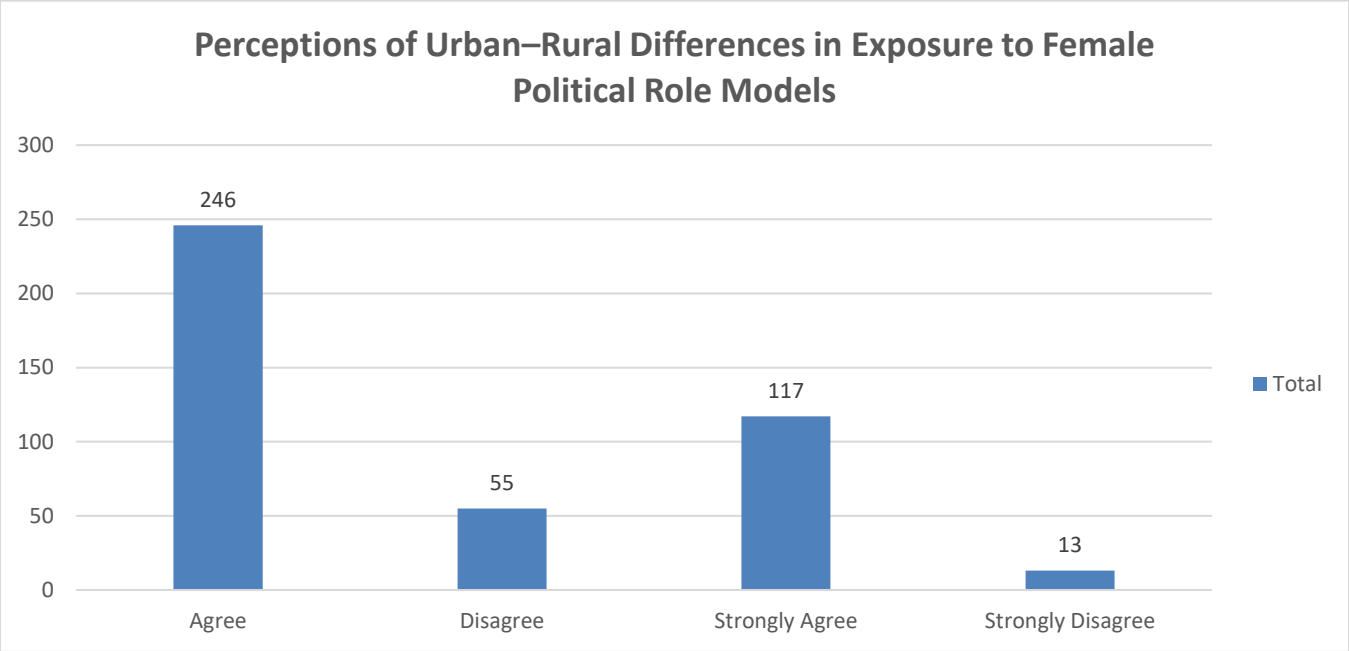
A majority of respondents expressed agreement that women in urban areas have greater political advantages than women in rural areas. Specifically, 135 urban respondents (56.25% of urban respondents) and 115 rural respondents (60% of rural respondents) agreed with this statement, while a further 59 urban respondents (24.58%) and 36 rural respondents (18.84%) strongly agreed. The pattern indicates broad consensus across both urban and rural populations, with stronger intensity of agreement observed among urban respondents. Overall, the findings suggest a shared perception that urban residence is associated with enhanced political opportunities for women.

Rural women face more cultural barriers to political participation than those in urban areas



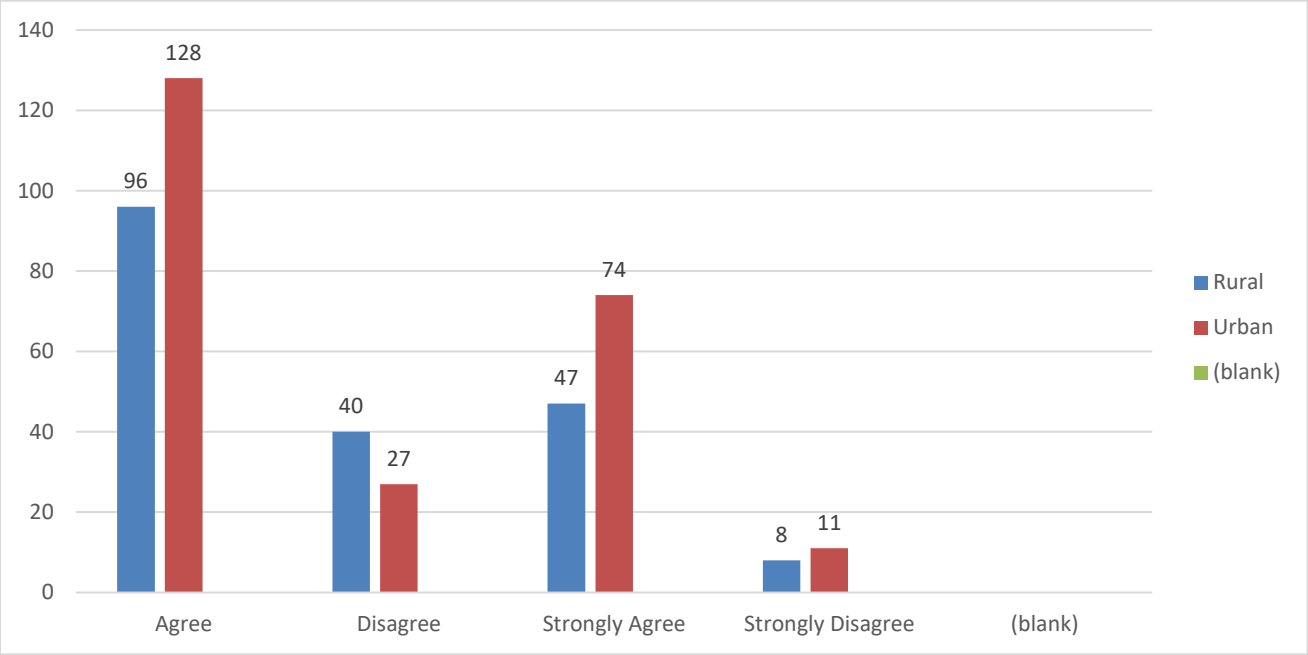
Out of the 431 respondents**,** 226 respondents (52.4%) agreed that rural women face more cultural barriers to political participation than their urban counterparts, while 104 respondents (24.1%) strongly agreed with this statement. Collectively, this indicates that over three-quarters of respondents perceive cultural barriers as a significant constraint on rural women's political participation, highlighting a pronounced urban–rural disparity in sociocultural challenges.

Urban women have more exposure to female political role models than those in rural areas



Out of the 431 respondents, a substantial majority expressed positive agreement with the statement that women in urban areas have greater exposure to female political role models than women in rural areas**.** Specifically, 246 respondents (57%) agreed, while an additional 117 respondents (27.14%) strongly agreed with the statement. This indicates a strong consensus among respondents that urban environments provide more visible female political representation, which may influence political awareness and participation among women.

Access to information about political processes is easier for women in urban areas than rural areas

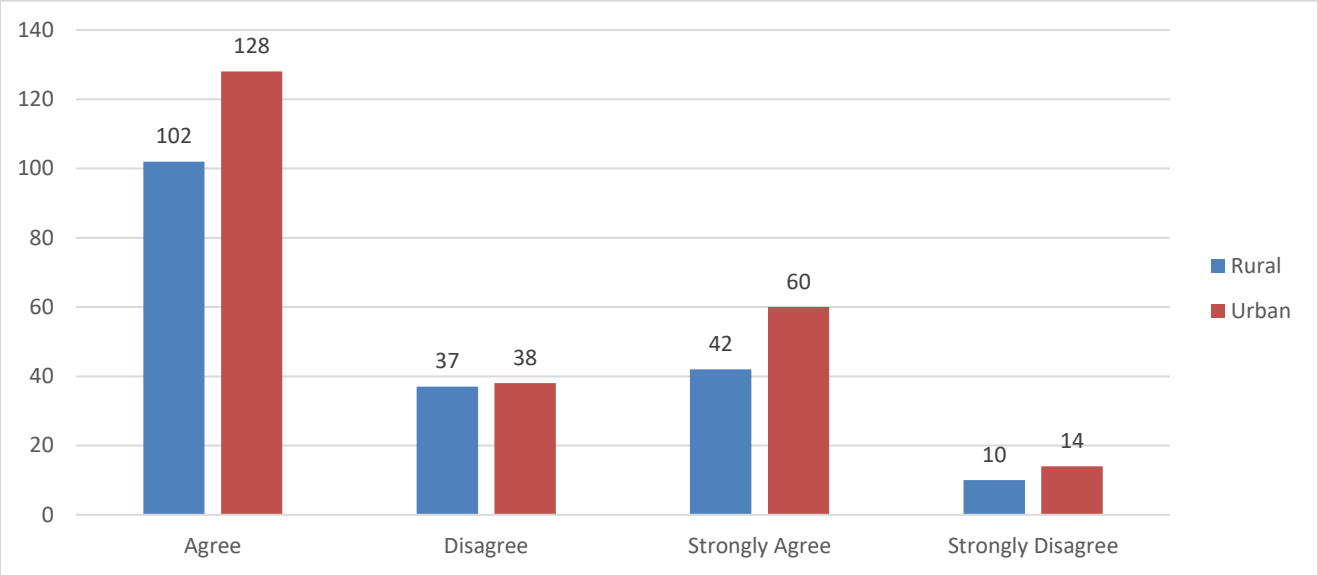


Among urban respondents**,** 53.3% (128 out of 240) agreed that access to information about political processes is easier for women in urban areas than in rural areas, while an additional 30.8% (74 respondents) strongly agreed with this statement.

Similarly, among rural respondents**,** 50.3% (96 out of 191) agreed that access to political information is easier for women in urban areas; however, a substantially smaller proportion, 14.1% (27 respondents)**,** strongly agreed.

Overall, while agreement with the statement was relatively high in both groups, the intensity of agreement was notably stronger among urban respondents, suggesting greater perceived advantages in information access for women residing in urban areas compared to their rural counterparts**.**

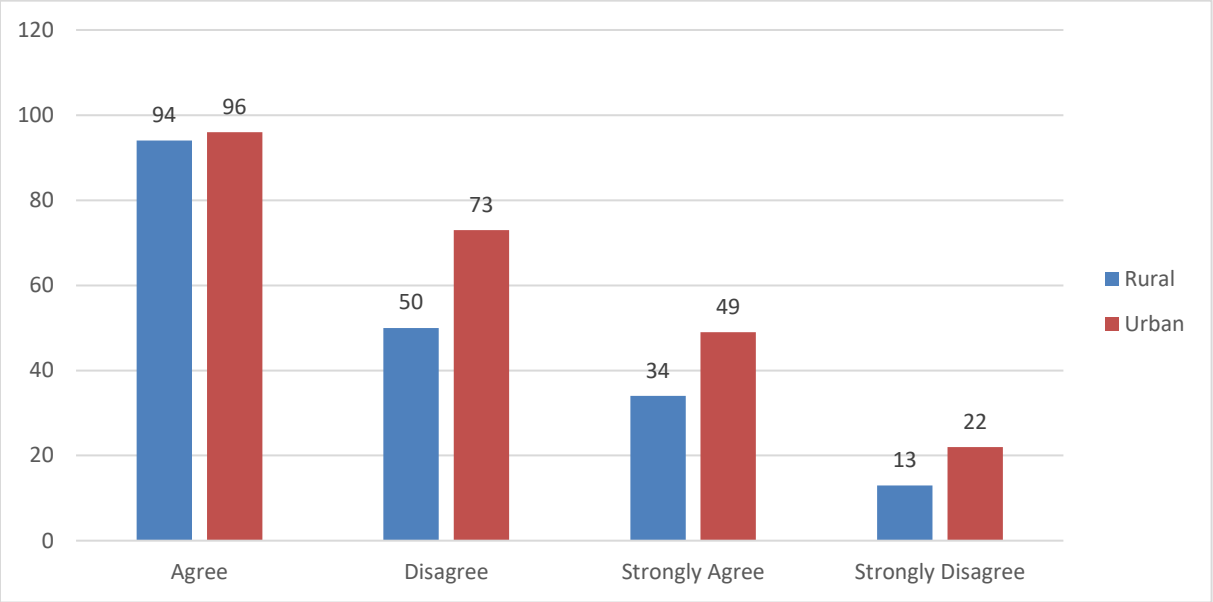
The level of family support for women's political ambition differs between urban and rural areas



Among urban respondents**,** 53.3% (128 out of 240) agreed that the level of family support for women's political ambition differs between urban and rural areas, while an additional 25.0% (60 respondents) strongly agreed with this statement. Similarly, among rural respondents**,** 53.4% (102 out of 191) agreed, and 22.0% (42 respondents) strongly agreed that differences exist in family support for women's political ambition based on place of residence.

Overall, the findings indicate a high level of consensus across both urban and rural populations, with a majority of respondents in each group either agreeing or strongly agreeing that family support for women's political ambition varies between urban and rural settings.

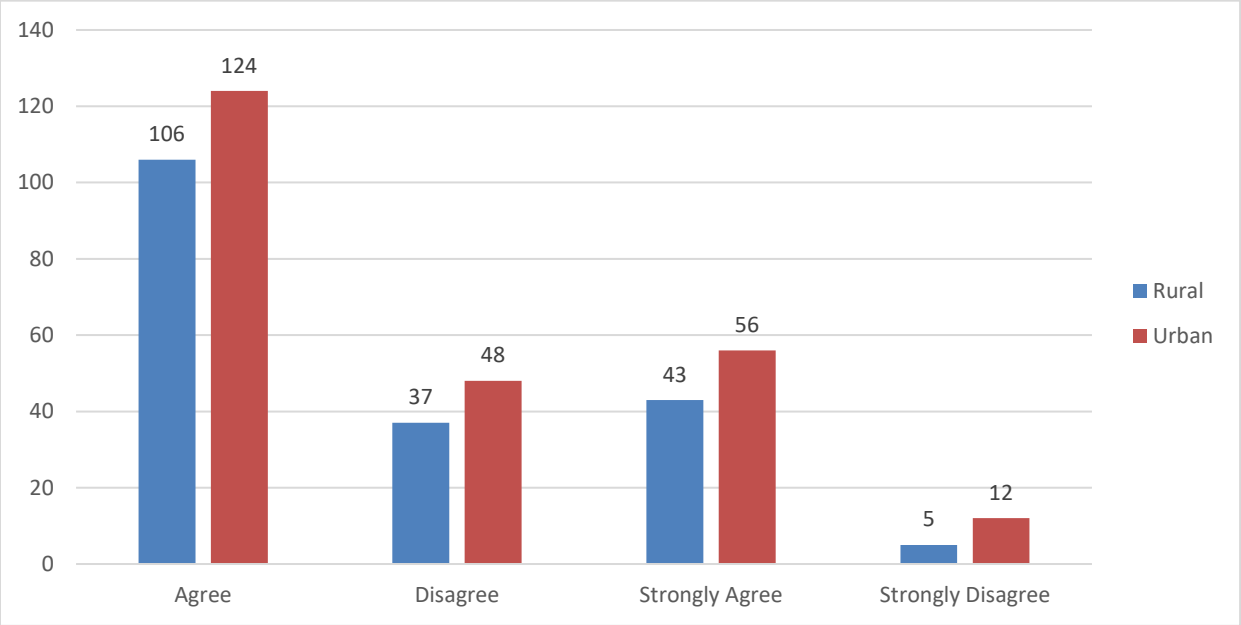
Urban women face less resistance from male politicians compared to rural women



Among urban respondents 240, 40.0% (96 respondents) agreed and 20.4% (49 respondents) strongly agreed that urban women face less resistance from male politicians compared to rural women. In contrast, 30.4% (73 respondents) of urban participants disagreed with this assertion.

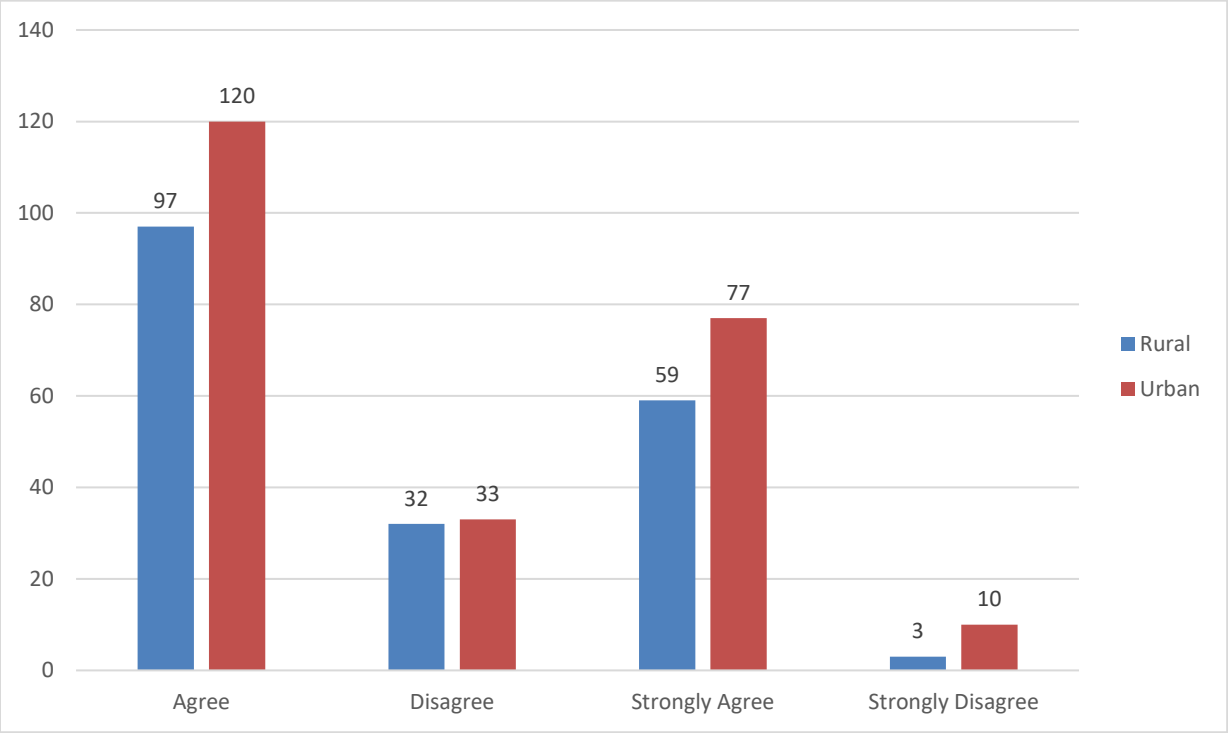
Similarly, among rural respondents 191, nearly half 49.2% (94 respondents) agreed and 17.8% (34 respondents) strongly agreed that urban women experience less resistance from male politicians than their rural counterparts, while 26.2% (50 respondents) expressed disagreement.

The level of community engagement in politics differs for women in urban and rural areas



Among urban respondents, 124 out of 240 (51.7%) agreed that the level of community engagement in politics differs for women in urban and rural areas, while an additional 56 respondents (23.3%) strongly agreed with this statement. Similarly, among rural respondents, 106 out of 191 (55.5%) agreed that women's political community engagement differs between urban and rural settings, and 43 respondents (22.5%) strongly agreed. Overall, these findings indicate a clear consensus across both urban and rural populations that meaningful differences exist in the level of women's community engagement in politics based on location.

Urban women have more financial resources to support their political campaigns than rural women

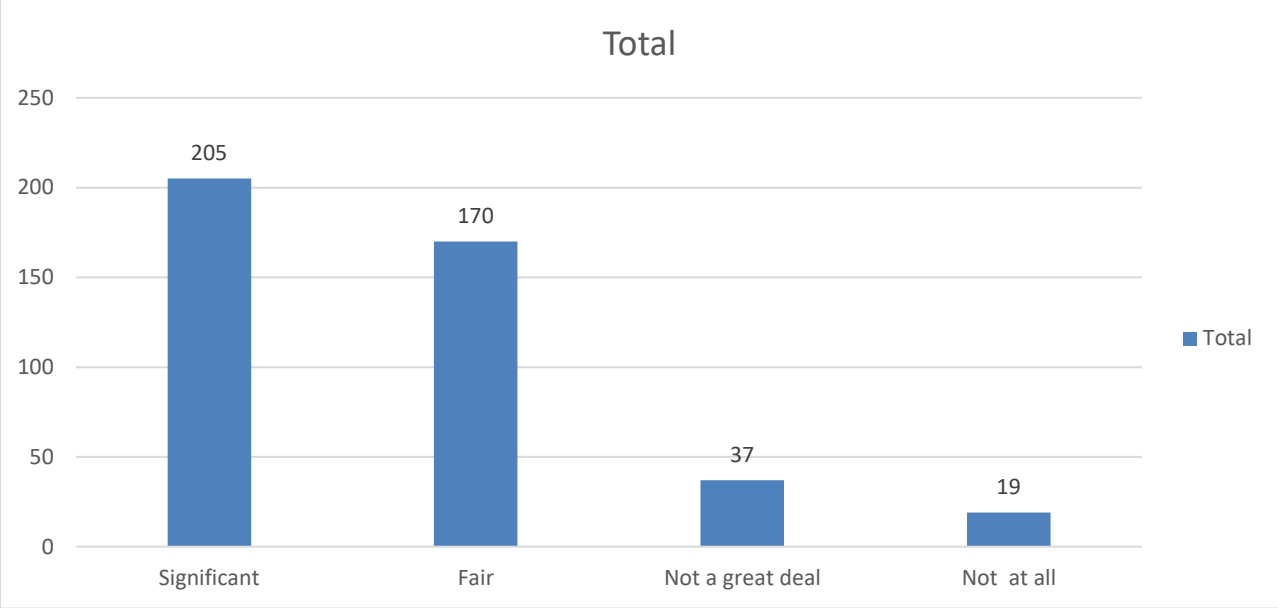


Among the respondents, 120 of 240 urban respondents (50%) agreed that women in urban areas have more financial resources to support their political campaigns compared to their rural counterparts, while 97 of 191 rural respondents (approximately 50.8%) expressed agreement with the same statement.

Furthermore, a notable proportion of respondents strongly agreed with this view, including 77 urban respondents (32.1%) and 59 rural respondents (30.9%). These results indicate a broadly shared perception across both urban and rural participants that urban women are better positioned financially to engage in political campaigns, with a slightly higher intensity of agreement observed among urban respondents.

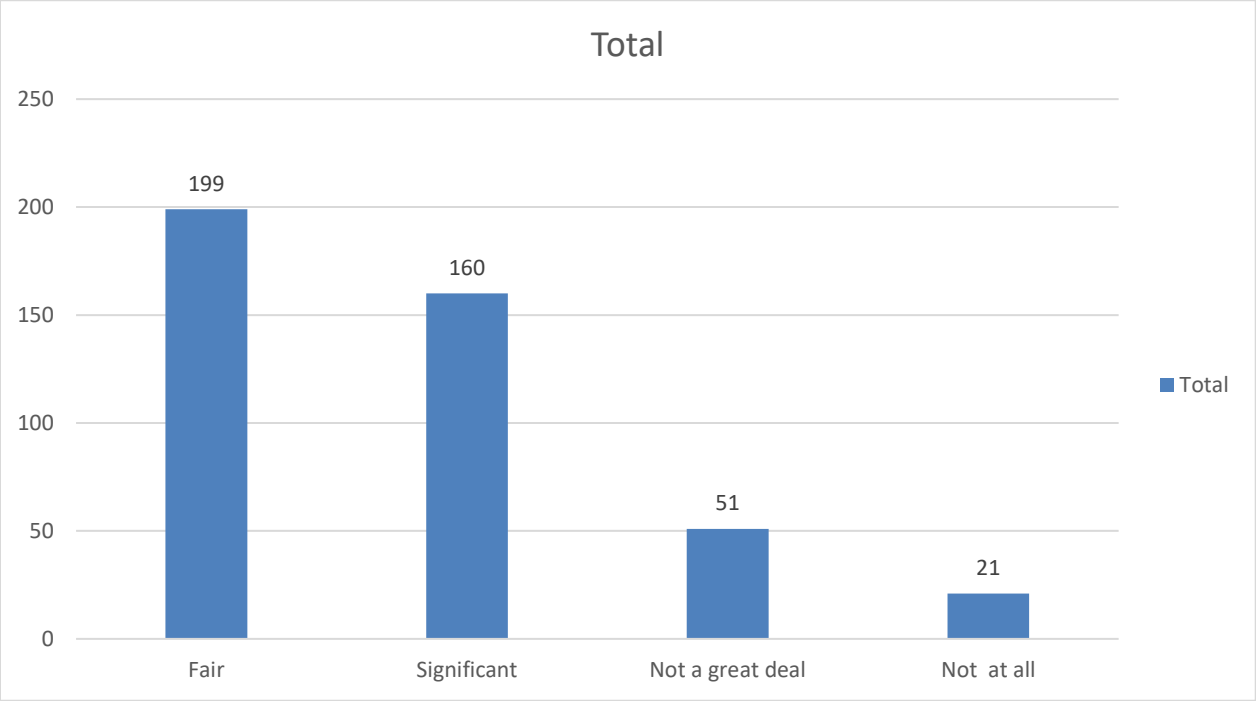
To what extent do the following challenges/barriers influence female Political Participation in your state?

Cultural norms and stereotypes about women in society



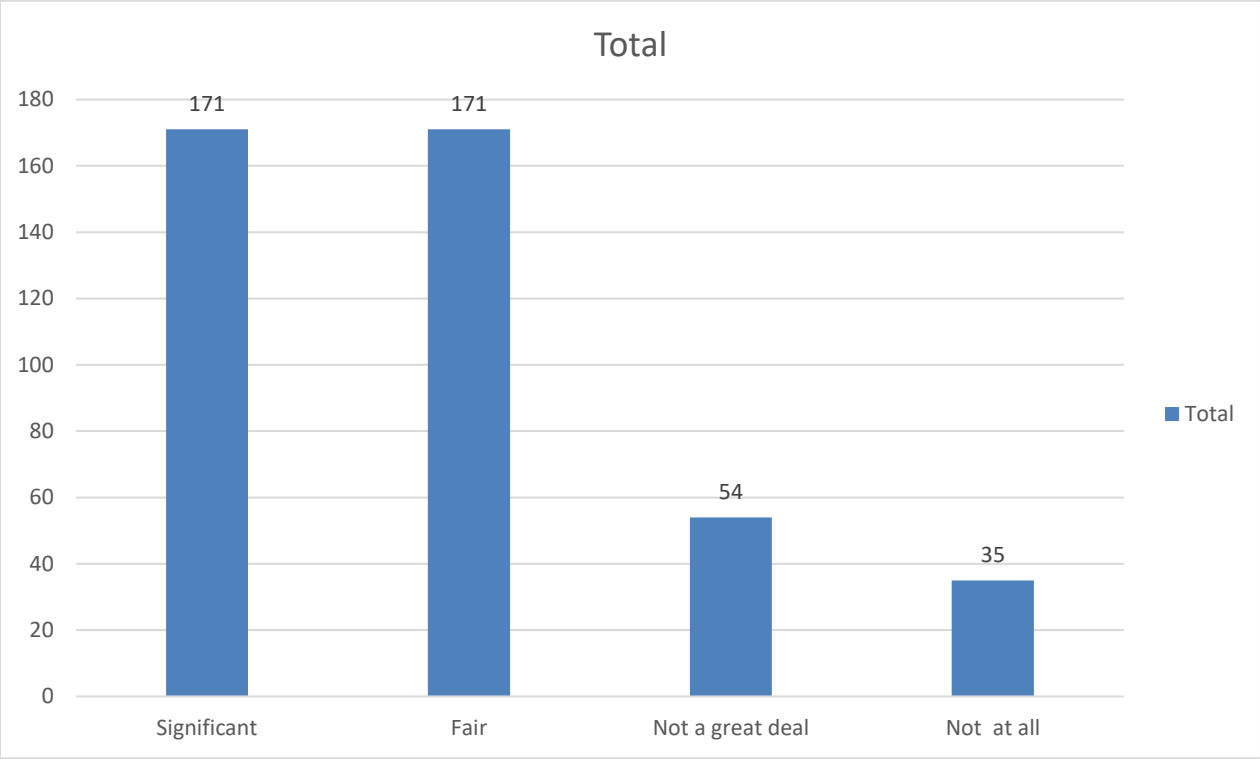
Majority of respondents perceived these barriers as significant. Out of 431 participants, 205 (47.6%) indicated that these challenges have a significant influence, 170 respondents (39.44%) considered them to have a fair influence, while 37 respondents (8.6%) felt that the impact is not a great deal. The remaining respondents either selected no influence or did not provide a response. This indicates that social-cultural factors remain a major impediment to women's political engagement in the surveyed states.

Religious beliefs/interpretation about women in society



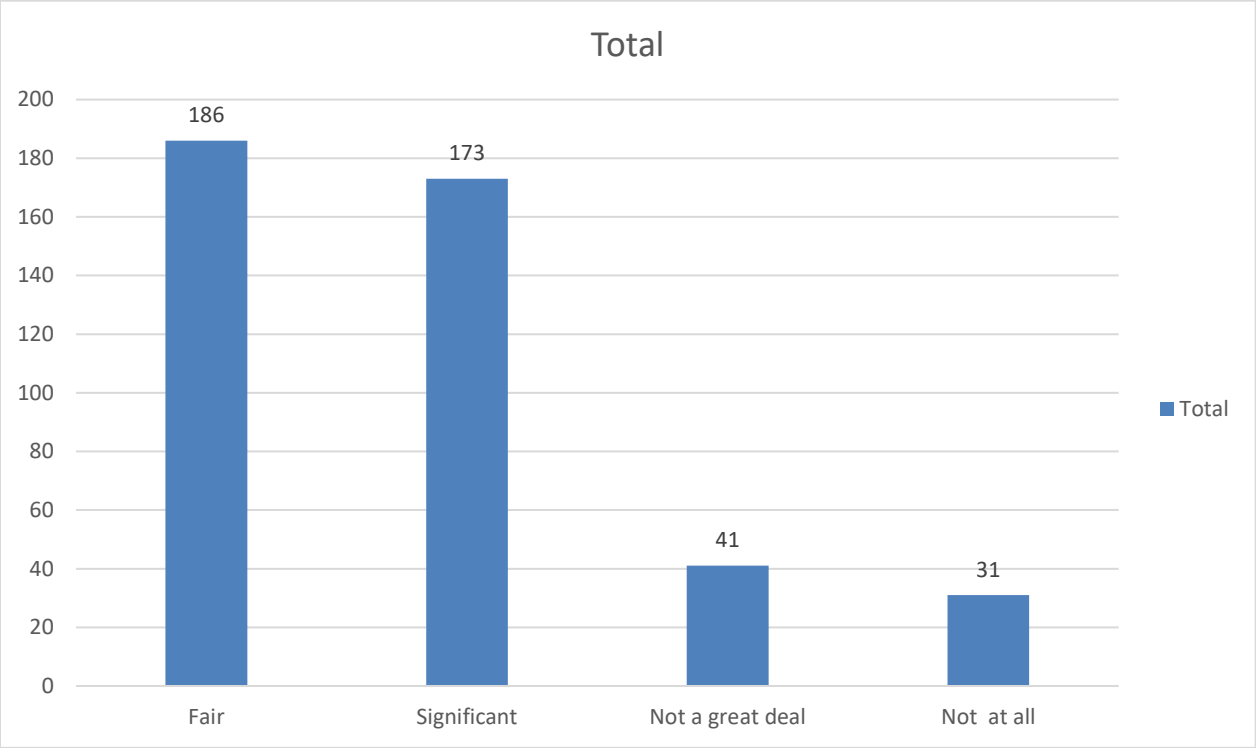
When asked to what extent social-cultural barriers, specifically religious beliefs and interpretations about women in society, influence female political participation in their state, respondents indicated varying levels of impact. Out of a total of 431 respondents, 199 (46.2%) rated these barriers as having a significant influence**,** 160 (37.1%) considered them to have a fair influence**,** while 51 (11.8%) believed they did not constitute a great deal of influence. These results suggest that a substantial proportion of respondents perceive religious and socio-cultural norms as key constraints on women's political engagement, although a notable minority perceive their effect as moderate or minimal.

Discriminatory or sexist working culture in Government/Parliament/state legislature



Respondents were asked to evaluate the extent to which social-cultural barriers, specifically a discriminatory or sexist working culture in government, parliament, or state legislature, influence female political participation in their state. Out of 431 respondents**,** 171 (39.7%) indicated that these barriers have **a** significant influence, while an equal number**,** 171 (39.7%)**,** considered their impact to be fair**.** A smaller group, 54 respondents (12.5%)**,** felt that these barriers do not have a great deal of influence on women's political participation.

Women's perception of the lack of safety and respect for women in the political sphere.

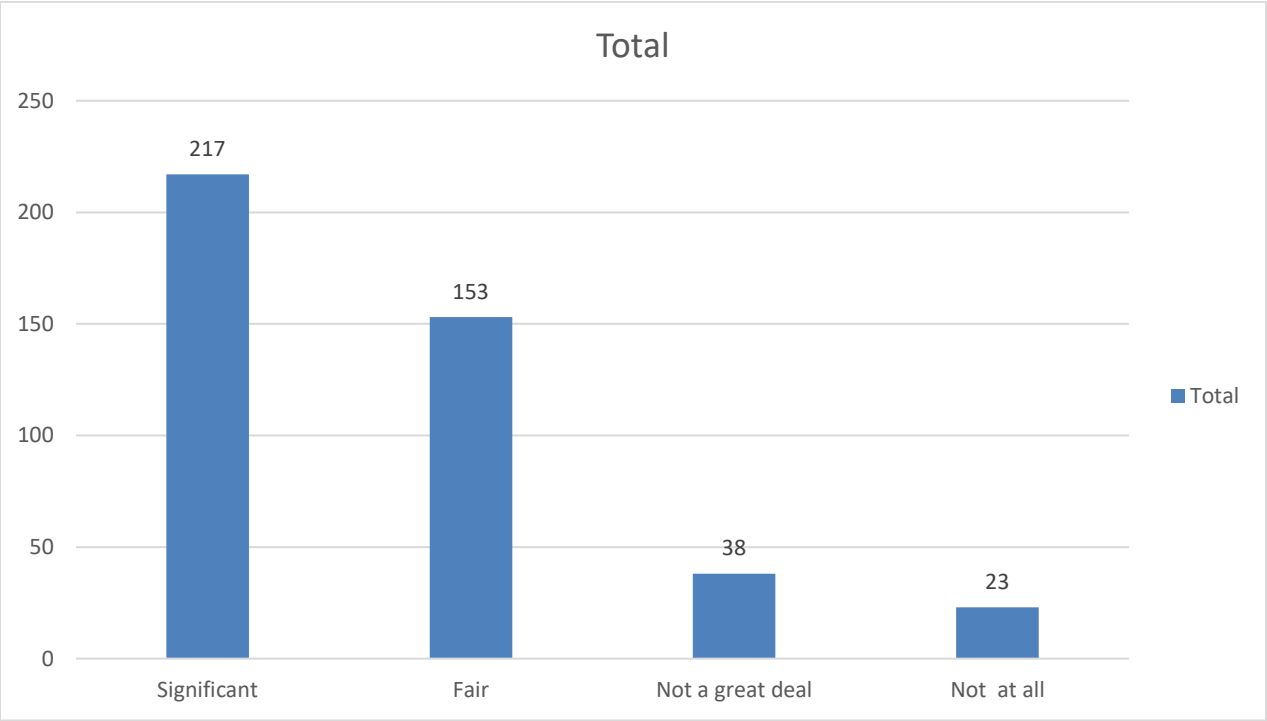


When asked to what extent social-cultural barriers—specifically women's perceptions of lack of safety and respect in the political sphere—influence female political participation in their state, respondents provided the following insights:

- 173 out of 431 respondents (40.1%) indicated that these barriers have a significant influence.
- 186 out of 431 respondents (43.2%) considered the impact to be fair.
- 41 out of 431 respondents (9.5%) felt that these barriers make not a great deal of difference.

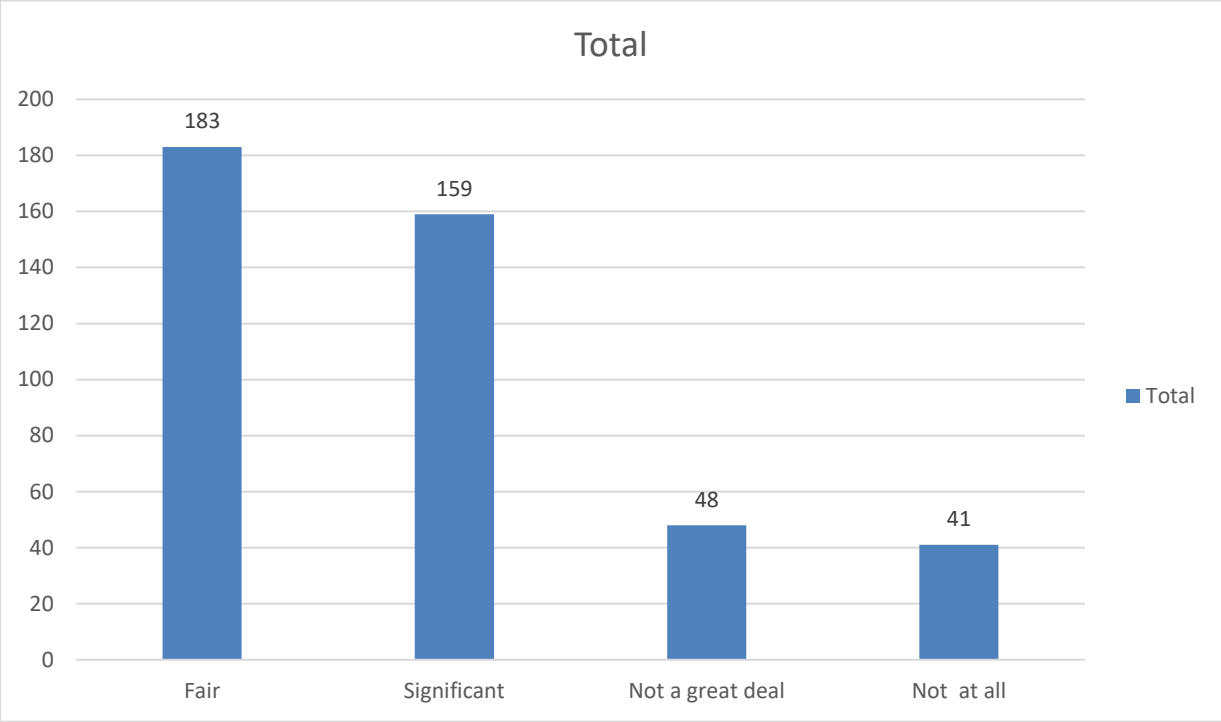
These results indicate that the majority of respondents perceive social-cultural barriers as having at least a moderate effect on women's engagement in politics, with only a small minority perceiving minimal impact.

Absence of gender equality policies/legal regulatory framework (constitution/election law) promoting women's participation



When respondents were asked to what extent institutional barriers, specifically the absence of gender equality policies or legal frameworks (such as constitutional or electoral laws) promoting women's participation, influence female political participation in their state, 217 out of 431 respondents (50.3%) indicated that these barriers have a significant impact**,** 153 respondents (35.5%) considered the impact to be fair, while 38 respondents (8.8%) felt it was not a great deal**.** This indicates that a majority of respondents perceive institutional barriers as a major factor limiting women's political participation.

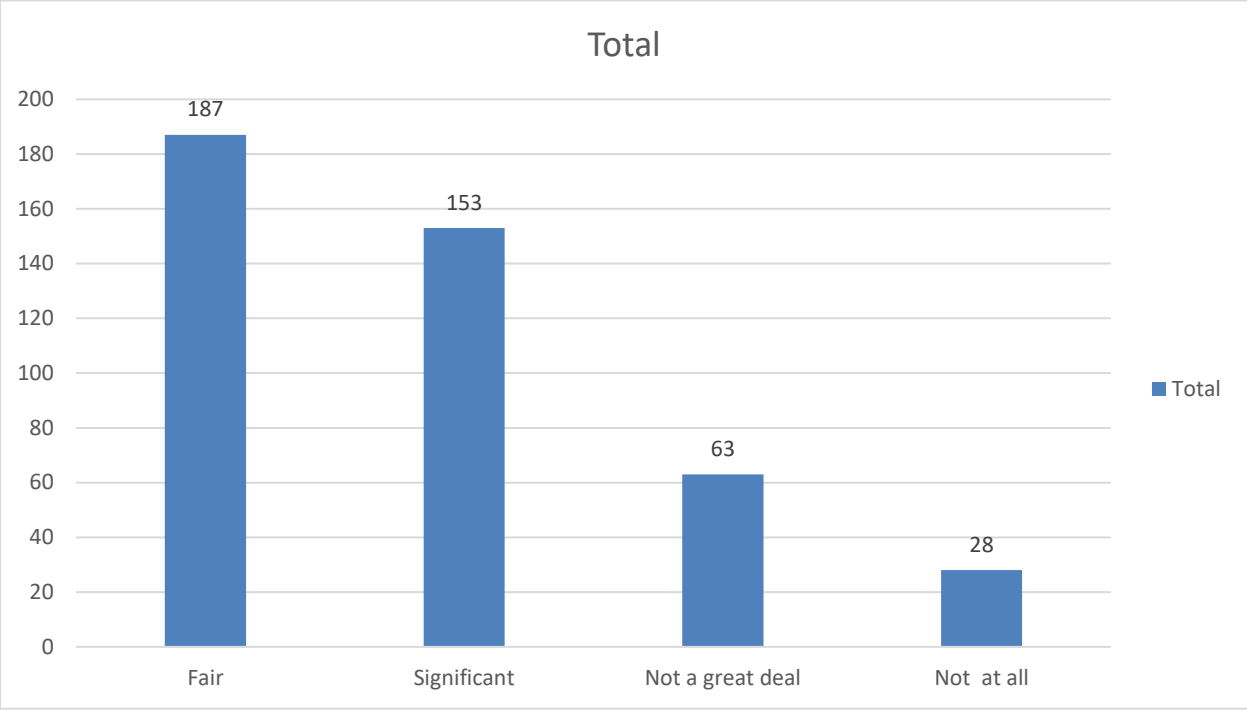
Legal discrimination of women



Respondents were asked to indicate the extent to which institutional barriers, specifically legal discrimination of women, influence female political participation in their state. Out of a total of 431 respondents, 159 (36.9%) considered these barriers significant, while 183 (42.5%) viewed them as fairly influential. A smaller proportion, 48 respondents (11.1%), felt that such barriers do not constitute a great deal of influence.

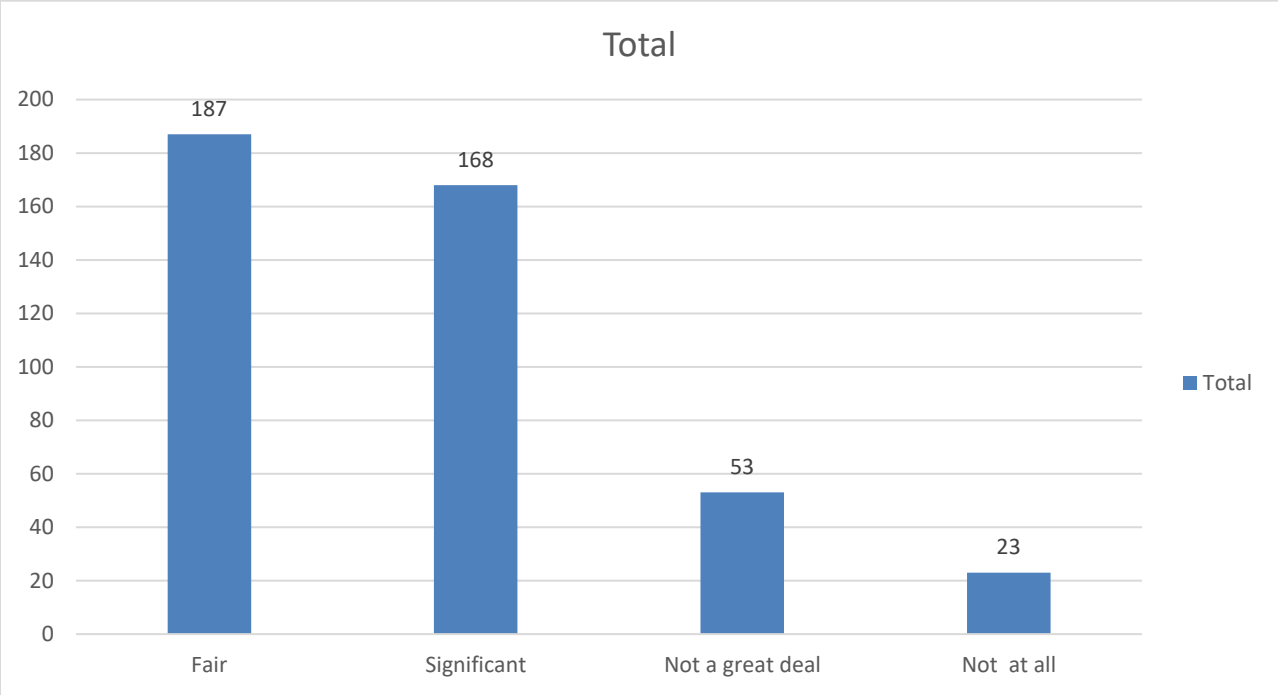
These results suggest that a majority of respondents perceive institutional barriers as meaningful constraints on women's political participation, highlighting the importance of addressing legal discrimination to enhance gender equity in political representation.

Lack of an enabling environment for civil society



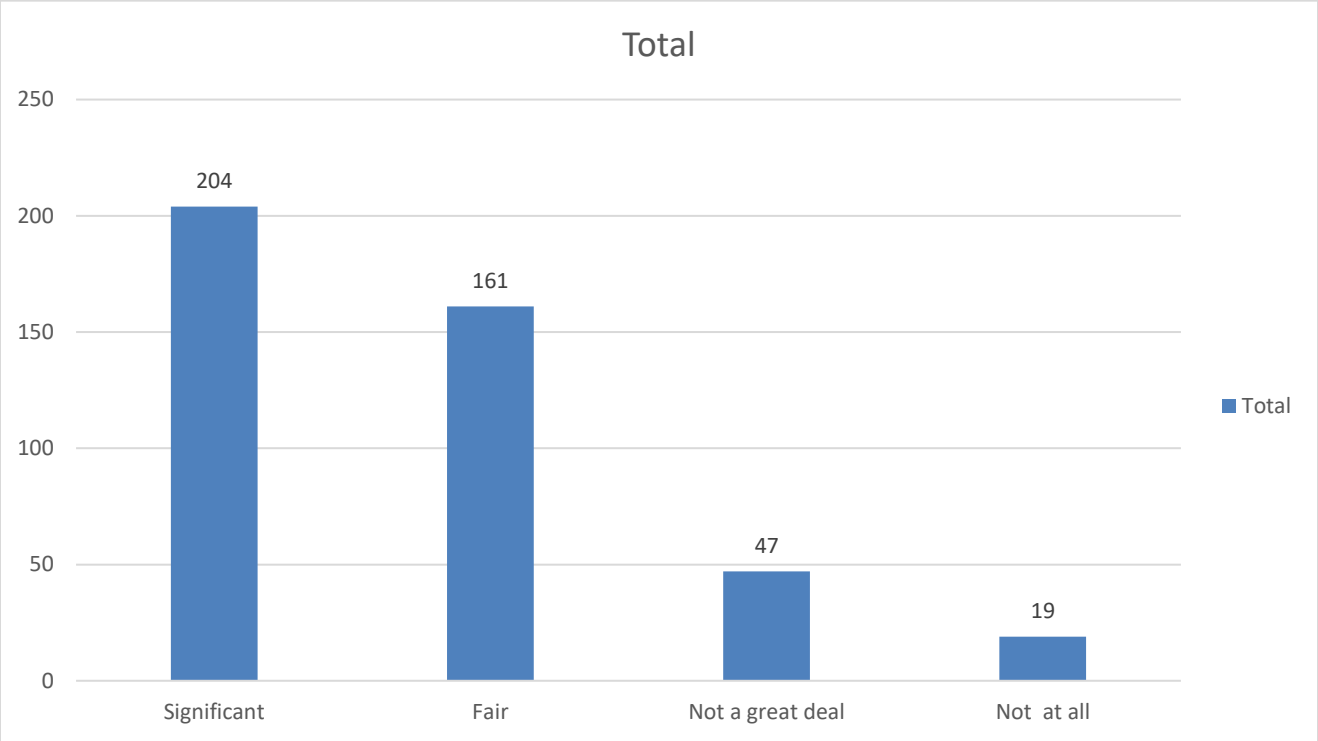
When respondents were asked about the extent to which institutional barriers such as the lack of an enabling environment for civil society affect female political participation in their state, 153 out of 431 respondents (35.5%) indicated that these barriers have a significant influence. A majority of 187 respondents (43.4%) felt that the impact of these barriers is fair, while 63 respondents (14.6%) considered it not a great deal. This distribution suggests that most respondents recognize institutional barriers as a meaningful, though variably perceived, constraint on women's political participation.

Gender blind institutions (governments, parliaments, political parties) and processes



When respondents were asked to assess the extent to which institutional barriers specifically gender-blind institutions such as governments, parliaments, political parties, and related political processes affect female political participation in their state, the results indicate a generally moderate to high perceived impact. Out of a total of 431 respondents**,** 187 (43.4%) described the influence of these barriers as *fair*, while 163 (37.8%) considered them *significant*. In contrast, a smaller proportion, 53 respondents (12.29%)**,** indicated that these institutional barriers are *not a great deal* of an influence. Overall, the findings suggest that most respondents perceive institutional barriers as a meaningful constraint on women's political participation, though views vary regarding the intensity of their impact.

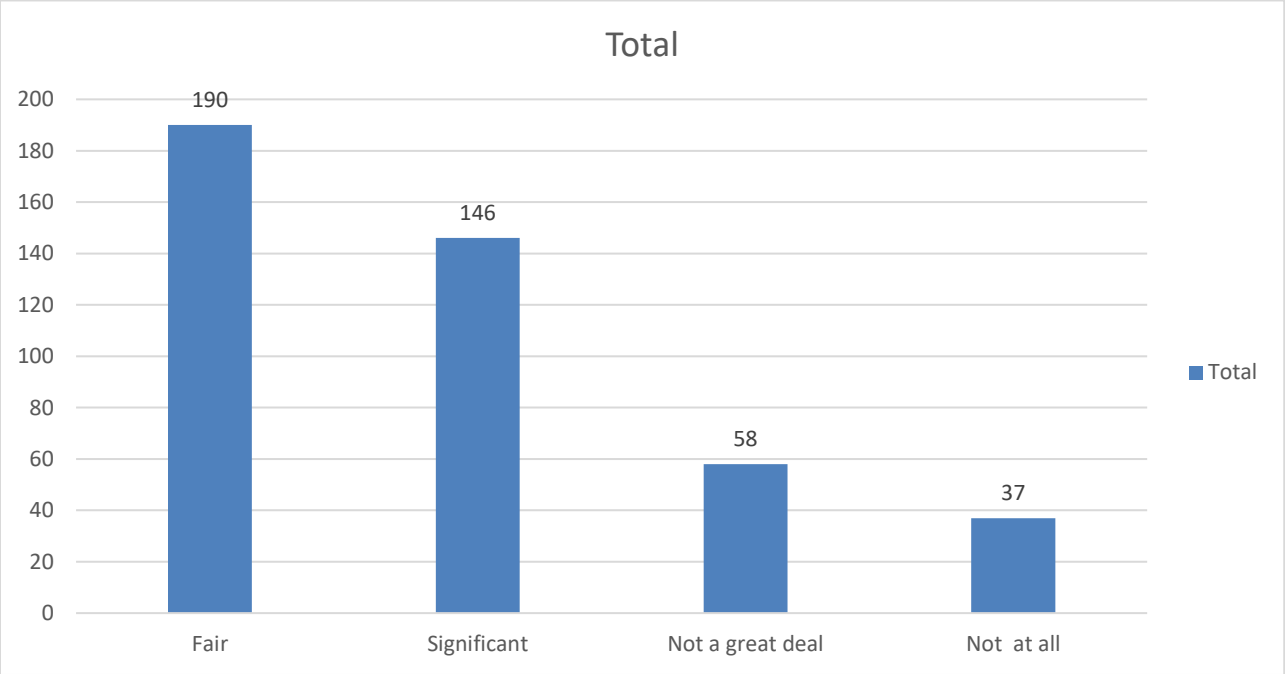
Unwillingness of political parties to promote women in their ranks



When respondents were asked to assess the extent to which institutional barriers, specifically the unwillingness of political parties to promote women within their ranks influence female political participation in their state, the majority perceived this challenge as substantial. Out of 431 respondents, 204 (47.3%) rated the influence as significant, while 161 respondents (37.4%) considered it fair. In contrast, only 47 respondents (10.9%) believed that this barrier is not a great deal.

Overall, these findings indicate that institutional resistance within political parties is widely regarded as a major constraint on women's political participation across the surveyed states.

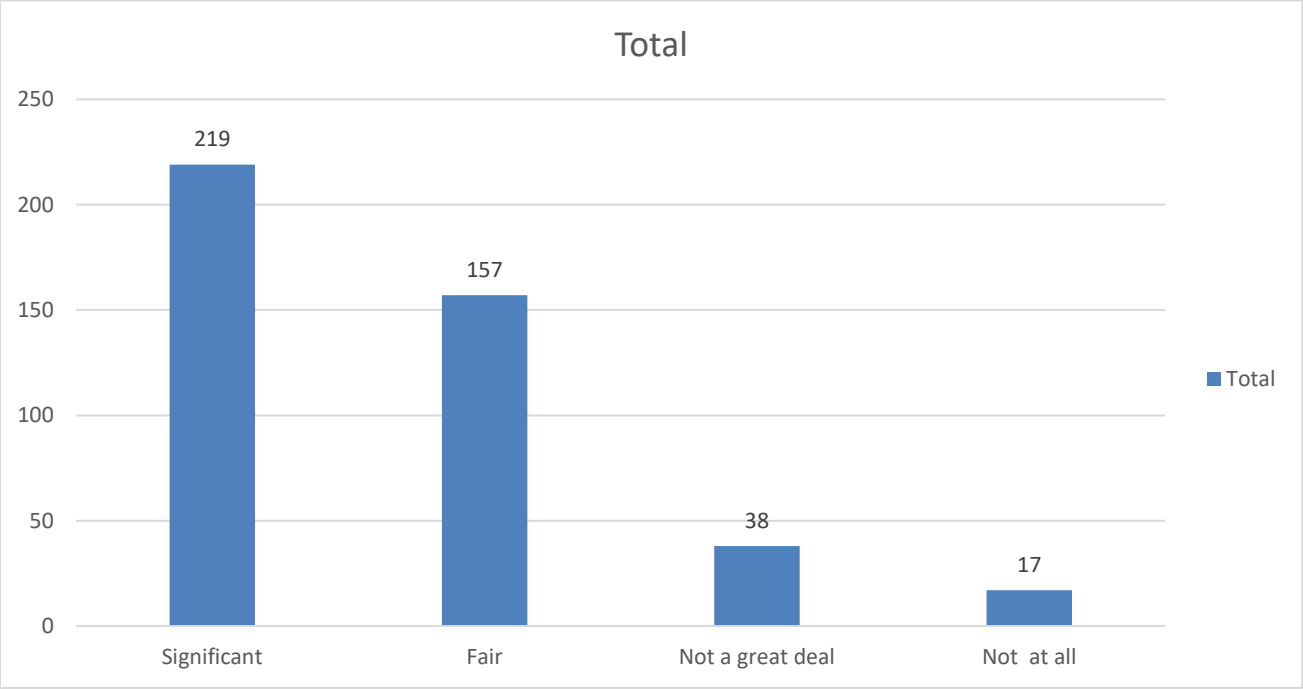
Biased media coverage of women



When respondents were asked to assess the extent to which biased media coverage of women influences female political participation in their state, the results indicate a predominantly moderate to strong perception of impact. Out of 431 respondents, 190 (44.1%) considered the influence to be fair, while 146 (33.9%) rated it as significant. In contrast, 58 respondents (13.5%) perceived biased media coverage as not a great deal of a barrier to female political participation.

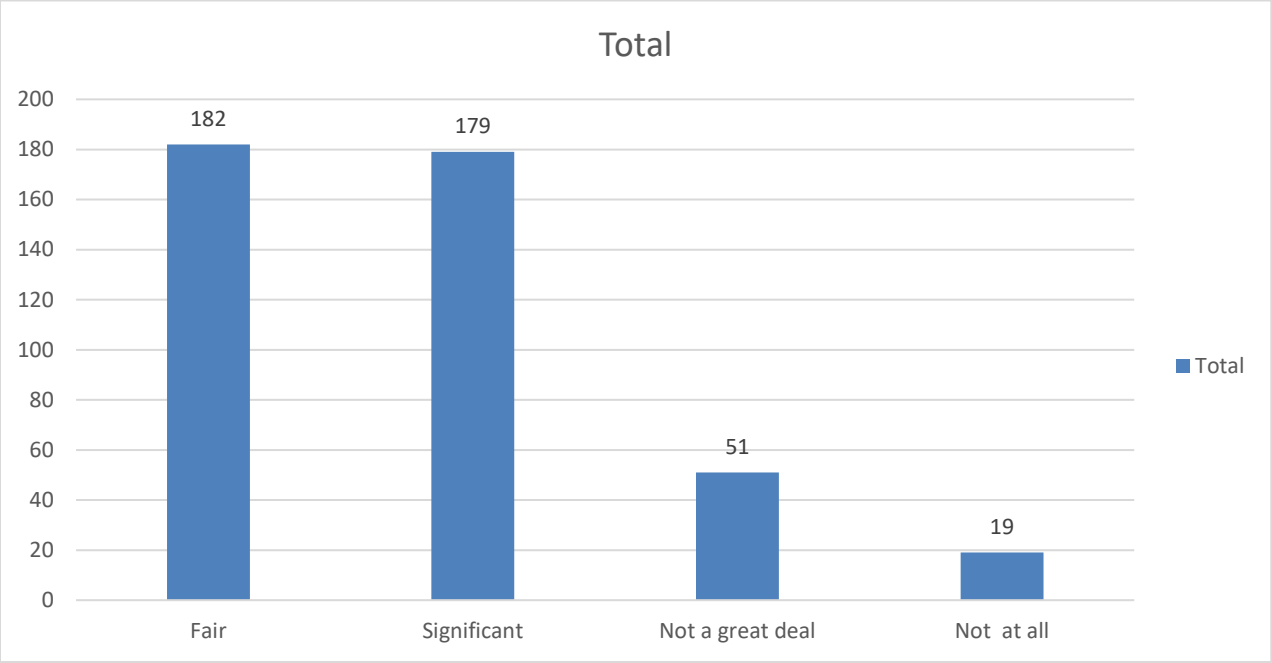
Overall, these findings suggest that a substantial proportion of respondents recognize biased media coverage as a meaningful institutional barrier, with the majority acknowledging at least a fair level of influence on women's political engagement.

Lack of solidarity among women



When respondents were asked to assess the extent to which lack of solidarity among women influences female political participation in their state, the majority perceived it as a substantial barrier. Specifically, 219 out of 431 respondents (50.8%) indicated that the issue has a significant influence. In comparison, 157 respondents (36.4%) considered the influence to be fair, while a much smaller proportion**,** 38 respondents (8.8%**)**, believed it is not a great deal. Overall, these findings suggest that insufficient solidarity among women is widely recognized as an important constraint on female political participation across the surveyed states.

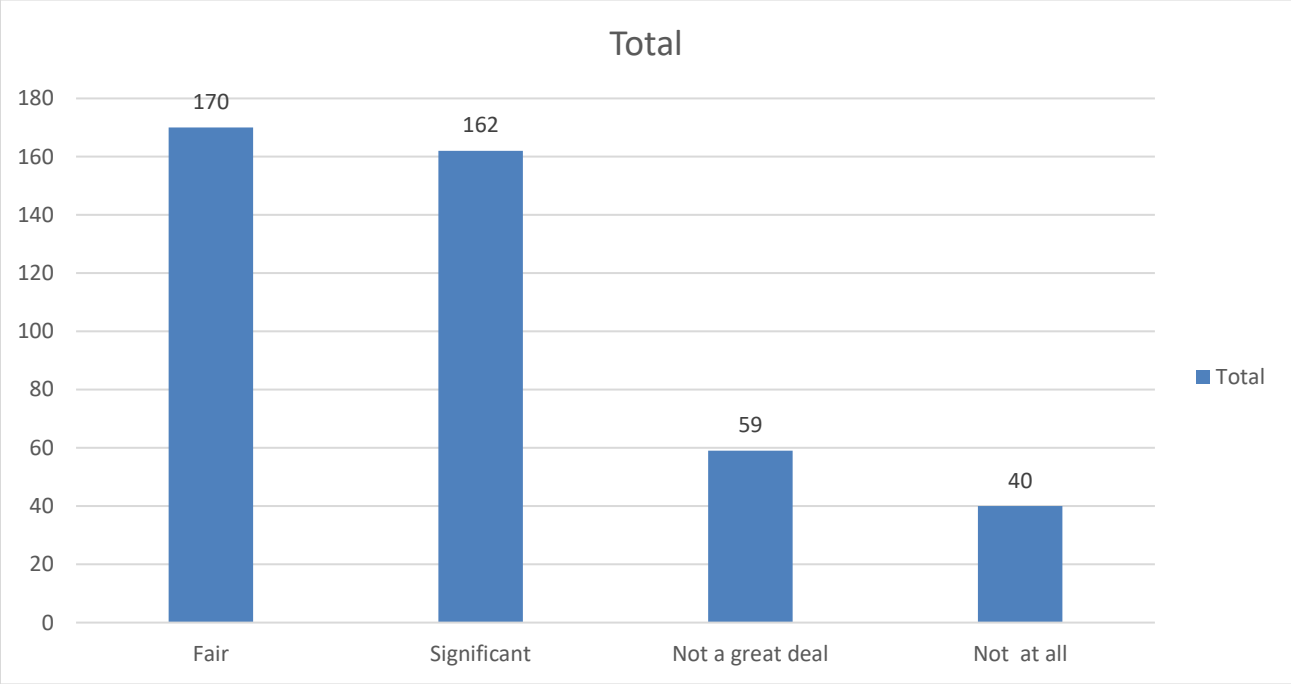
Lack of financial resources and skills among women



When respondents were asked to assess the extent to which lack of financial resources and skills among women influences female political participation in their state, the majority indicated that this barrier has a meaningful impact. Specifically, 179 out of 431 respondents rated the challenge as significant, while 182 out of 431 considered it fair. In contrast, a smaller proportion 51 out of 431 respondents reported that this factor is not a great deal in influencing female political participation.

Overall, these findings suggest that financial and capacity-related constraints are widely perceived as important barriers, with most respondents acknowledging at least a moderate level of influence on women's political engagement.

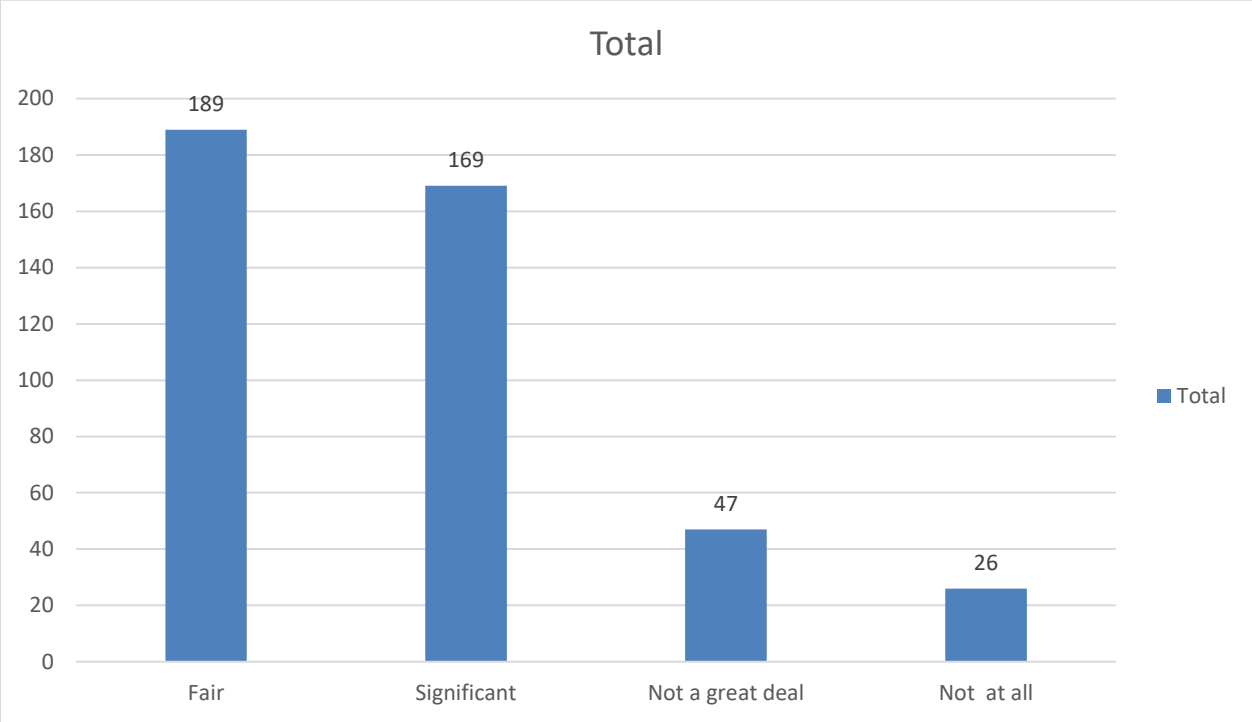
Lack of education and literacy among women



When respondents were asked to assess the extent to which lack of education and literacy among women influences female political participation in their state, the results indicate a broadly shared recognition of its importance as a barrier. Out of 431 respondents, 162 (37.6%) rated the barrier as having a significant influence, while 170 (39.4%) considered its impact to be fair. In contrast, 59 respondents (13.7%) indicated that it is not a great deal of a challenge.

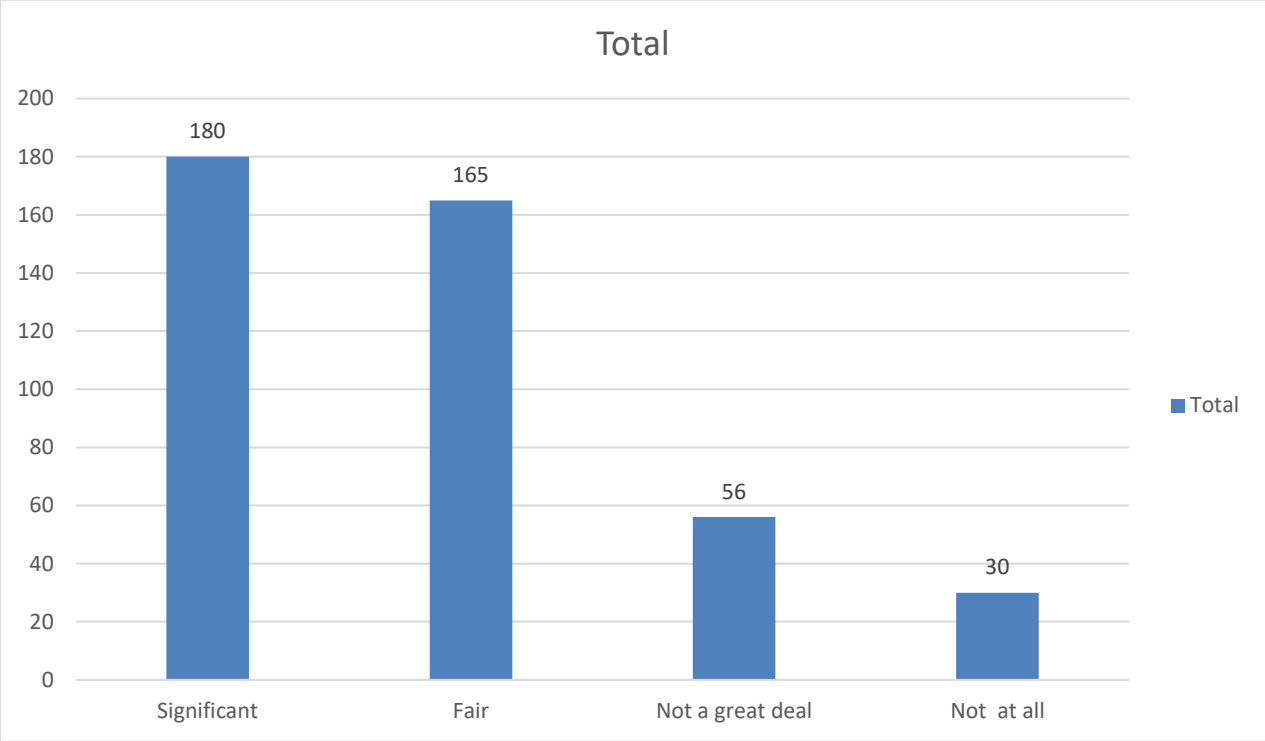
Overall, the findings suggest that a substantial majority of respondents perceive educational and literacy limitations as a meaningful constraint on women's political participation.

Lack of tools (manuals and guidelines) on gender equality and women's political participation



When respondents were asked to assess the extent to which the lack of tools, such as manuals and guidelines on gender equality and women's political participation, influences female political participation in their state, the findings indicate a substantial perceived impact. Out of a total of 431 respondents, 189 (43.9%) rated the barrier as significant, while 169 respondents (39.2%) considered it fair in its influence. In contrast, only 47 respondents (10.9%) indicated that this challenge is not a great deal, suggesting that the majority of respondents view inadequate tools and resources as a meaningful constraint on women's political participation.

Lack of reliable information/research on gender equality issues

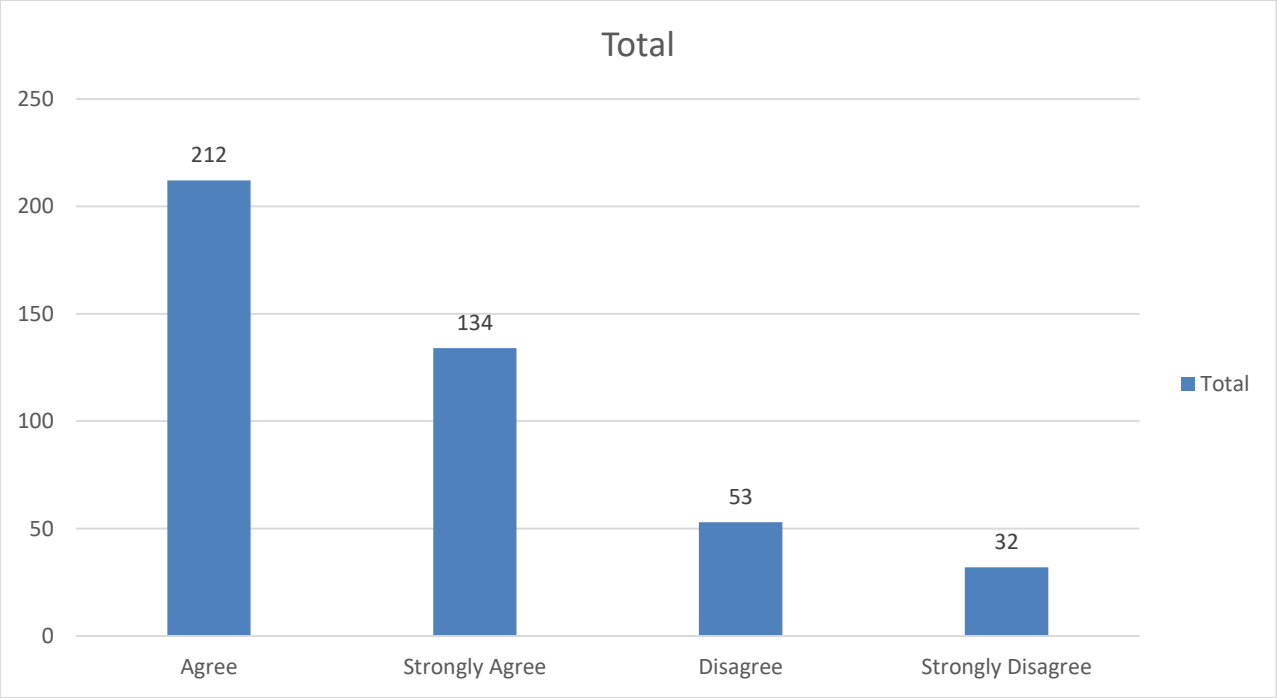


When respondents were asked to assess the extent to which lack of reliable information and research on gender equality issues influences female political participation in their state, the findings indicate a generally high perceived impact. Out of the 431 respondents, 180 (41.8%) rated this barrier as significant, while 165 (38.3%) considered it fair. In contrast, 56 respondents (13.0%) indicated that it is not a great deal of a barrier.

Overall, the results suggest that insufficient access to reliable gender-related information and research is widely perceived as a meaningful constraint on female political participation, with a substantial majority of respondents acknowledging at least a moderate level of influence

Strategies females should apply to effectively promote their meaningful political Participation and increase representation in your state

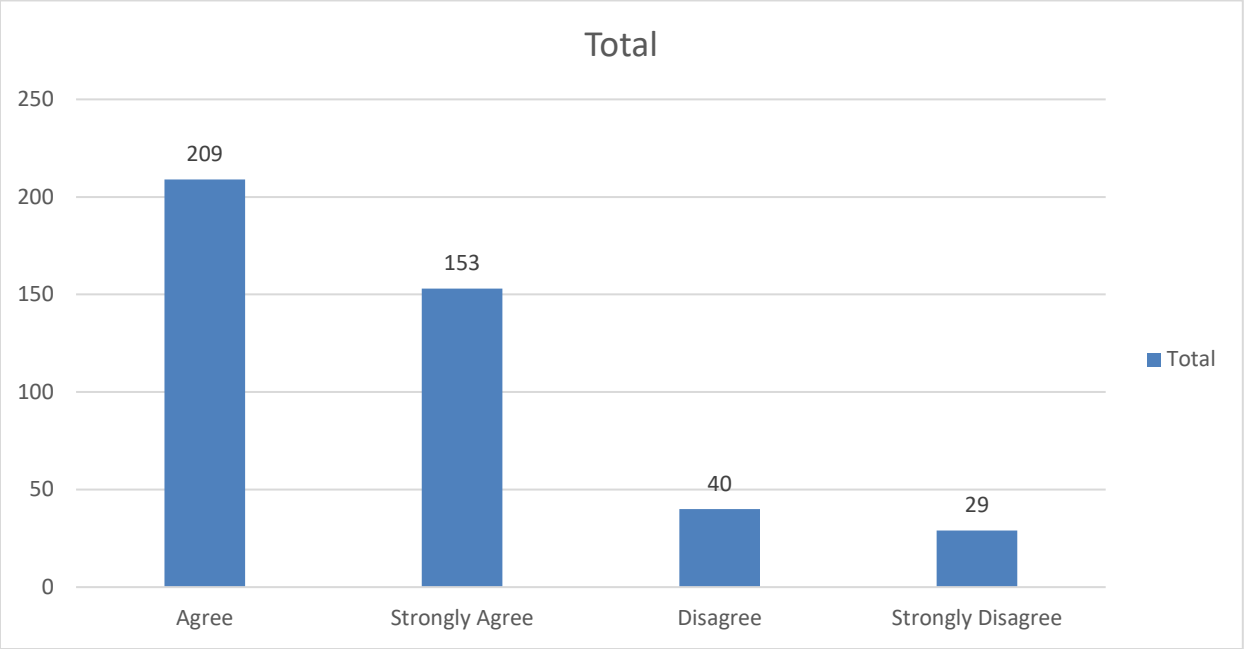
Plan their own political careers and learn to promote themselves through political party ranks



When respondents were asked whether women should plan their own political careers and actively promote themselves through political party ranks as a strategy to enhance meaningful political participation and increase representation within their state, the majority expressed strong support for this approach.

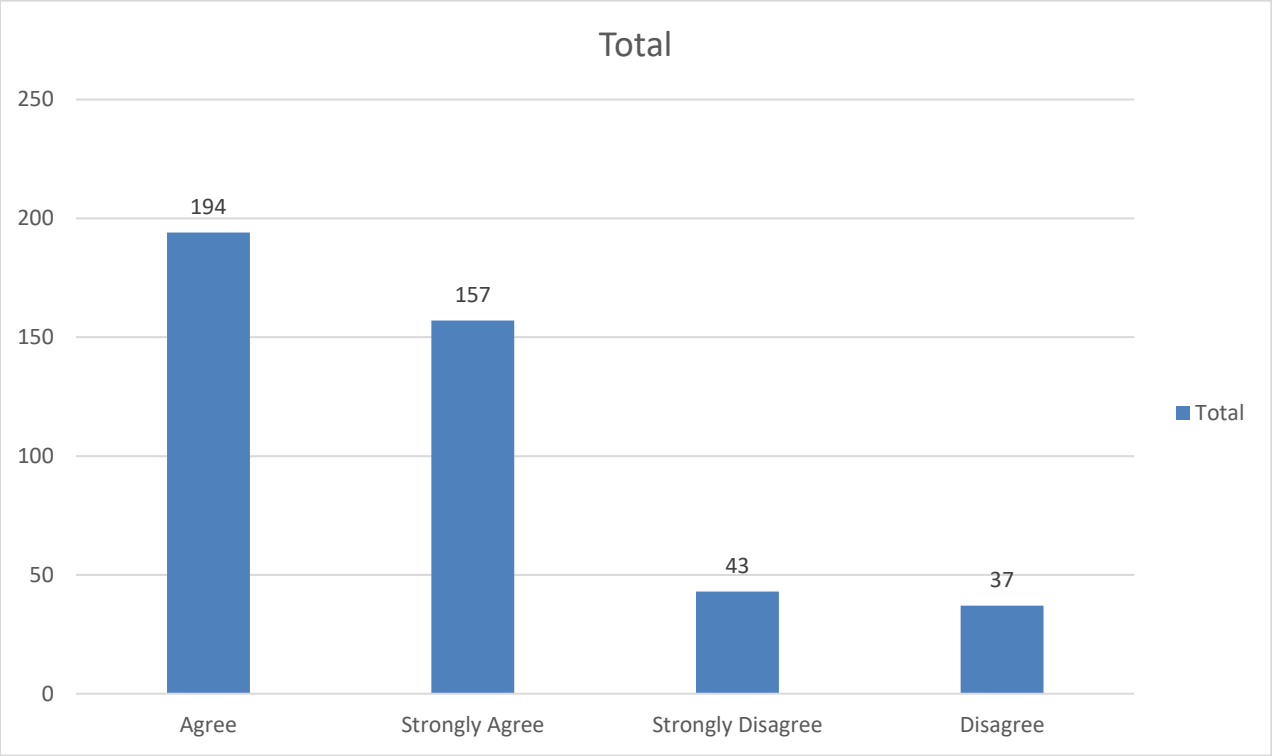
Out of 431 respondents, 212 (49.2%) strongly agreed and 134 (31.1%) agreed with the statement, indicating broad consensus on the importance of intentional career planning and self-promotion in political advancement. In contrast, 53 respondents (12.3%) disagreed, reflecting comparatively limited opposition to the strategy. Overall, the findings suggest that respondents overwhelmingly perceive proactive career development within party structures as a critical pathway for improving women's political representation.

Build partnerships with other women to act collectively on issues of concern



When respondents were asked whether building partnerships with other women to act collectively on issues of concern is an effective strategy for promoting meaningful political participation and increasing representation in their state, the majority expressed strong support for this approach. Specifically**,** 153 out of 431 respondents (35.5%) strongly agreed, while 209 respondents (48.5%) agreed with the statement. In contrast, 40 respondents (9.3%) disagreed, indicating limited opposition to the strategy. Overall, the findings suggest a broad consensus among respondents that collective action and partnership-building among women are perceived as critical mechanisms for strengthening women's political participation and representation at the state level.

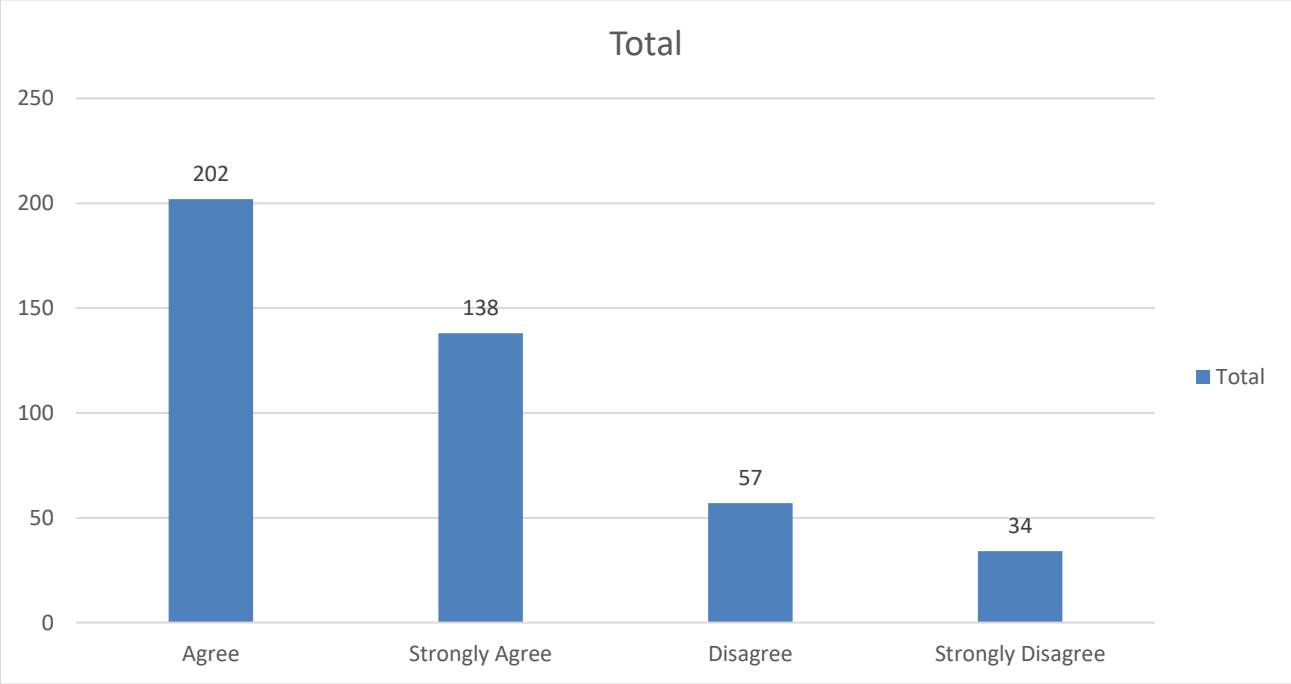
Engage men as partners and gender advocates to act collectively on issues of concern



When respondents were asked about strategies women should apply to effectively promote meaningful political participation and increase representation in their state specifically, engaging men as partners and gender advocates, 157 out of 431 respondents (36.4%) strongly agreed, while 194 respondents (45.0%) agreed. A smaller proportion, 53 respondents (12.3%) disagreed, indicating that the majority of participants recognize the value of collaborative engagement with men in advancing women's political participation.

This suggests a broad consensus on the importance of including male allies as part of gender advocacy efforts, highlighting it as a key strategy for increasing representation and influence in political processes.

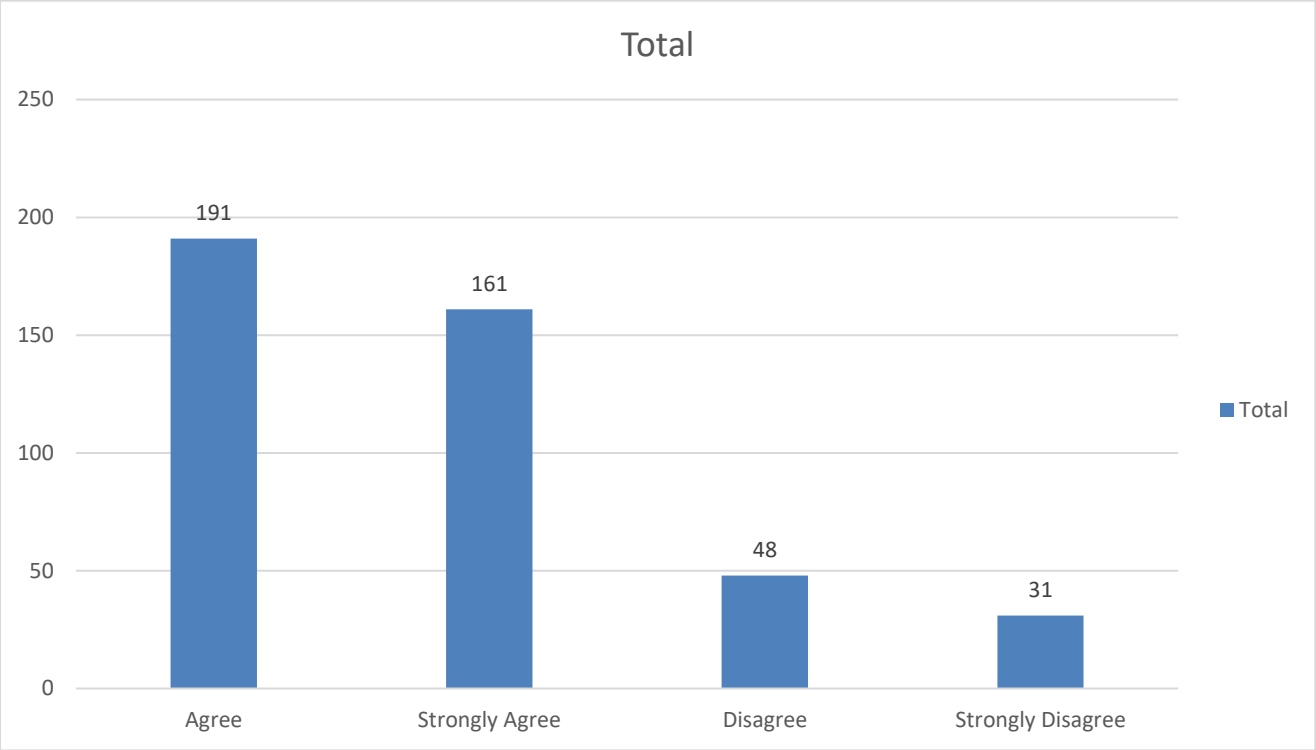
Learn to identify gender-based political manipulation



When asked about strategies females should adopt to effectively promote meaningful political participation and increase representation specifically, the strategy of learning to identify gender-based political manipulation 138 out of 431 respondents (32%) strongly agreed, 202 respondents (47%) agreed, and 57 respondents (13%) disagreed.

Overall, this indicates that a significant majority of respondents (**79%**) recognize the importance of awareness and understanding of gender-based political manipulation as a key strategy for enhancing female political engagement in their state.

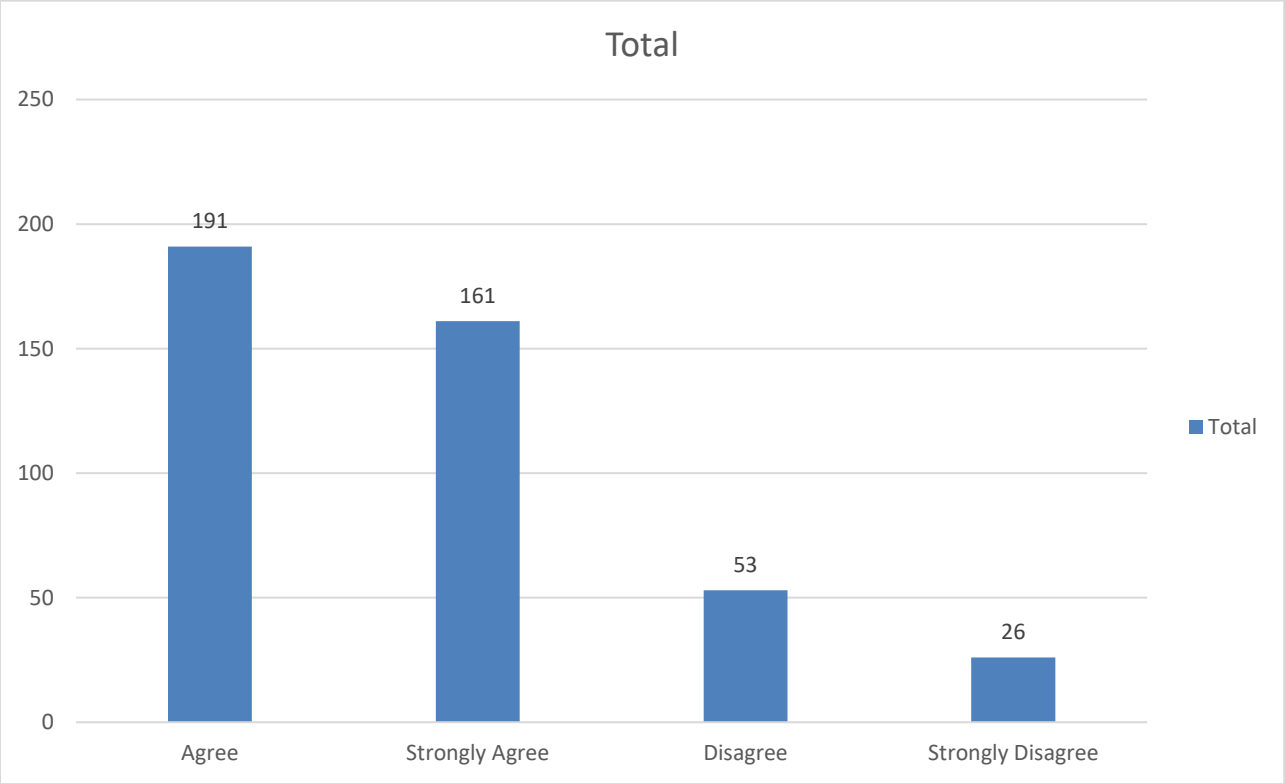
Build partnerships with other women to act collectively on issues of concern



A total of 431 respondents provided feedback on the strategy: "Build partnerships with other women to act collectively on issues of concern" as a means to promote meaningful political participation and increase representation. Of these respondents, 161 (37.4%) strongly agreed, and 191 (44.3%) agreed, indicating strong overall support for the strategy. Conversely, 48 respondents (11.1%) disagreed, suggesting a smaller proportion of skepticism or differing perspectives regarding its effectiveness.

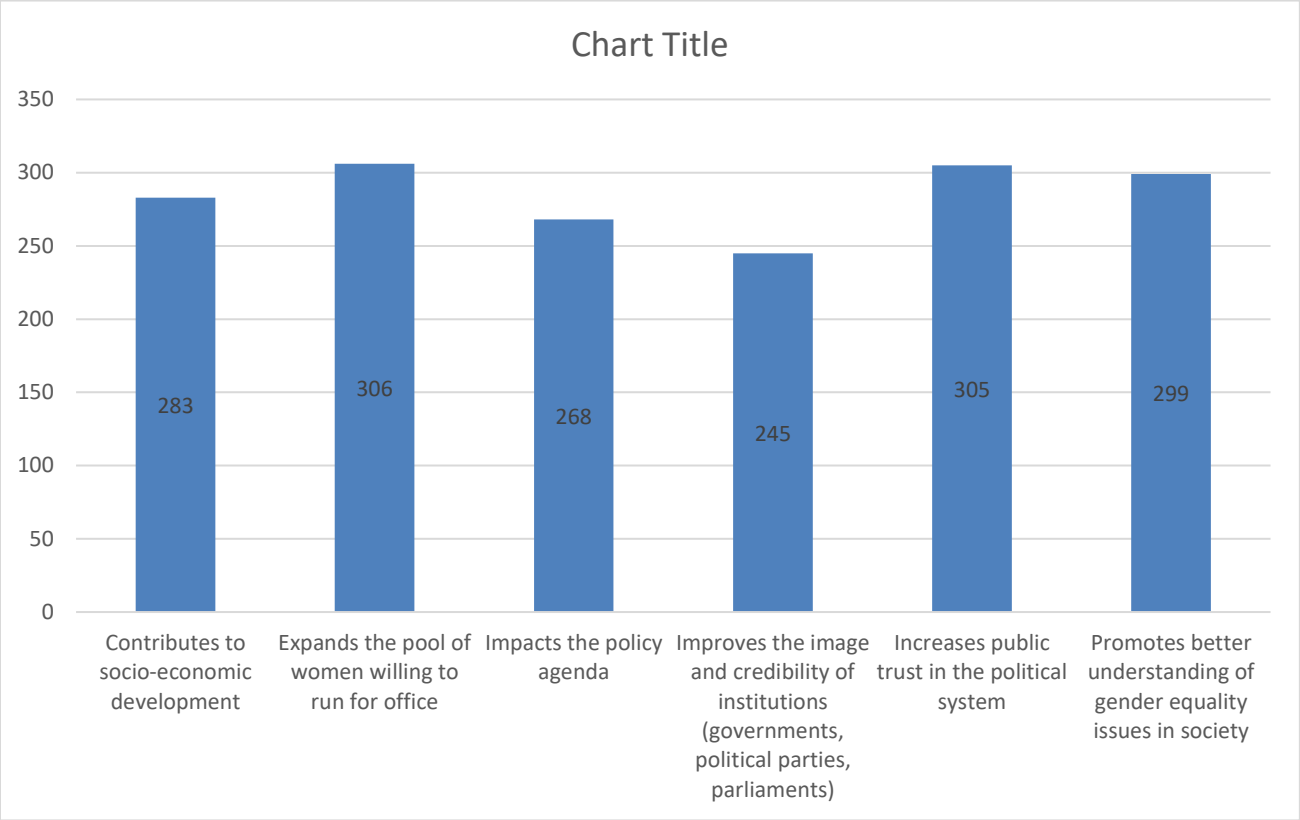
These results highlight that collaborative efforts among women are widely perceived as a key approach to improving political engagement and representation in the surveyed states.

Engage men as partners and gender advocates to act collectively on issues of concern



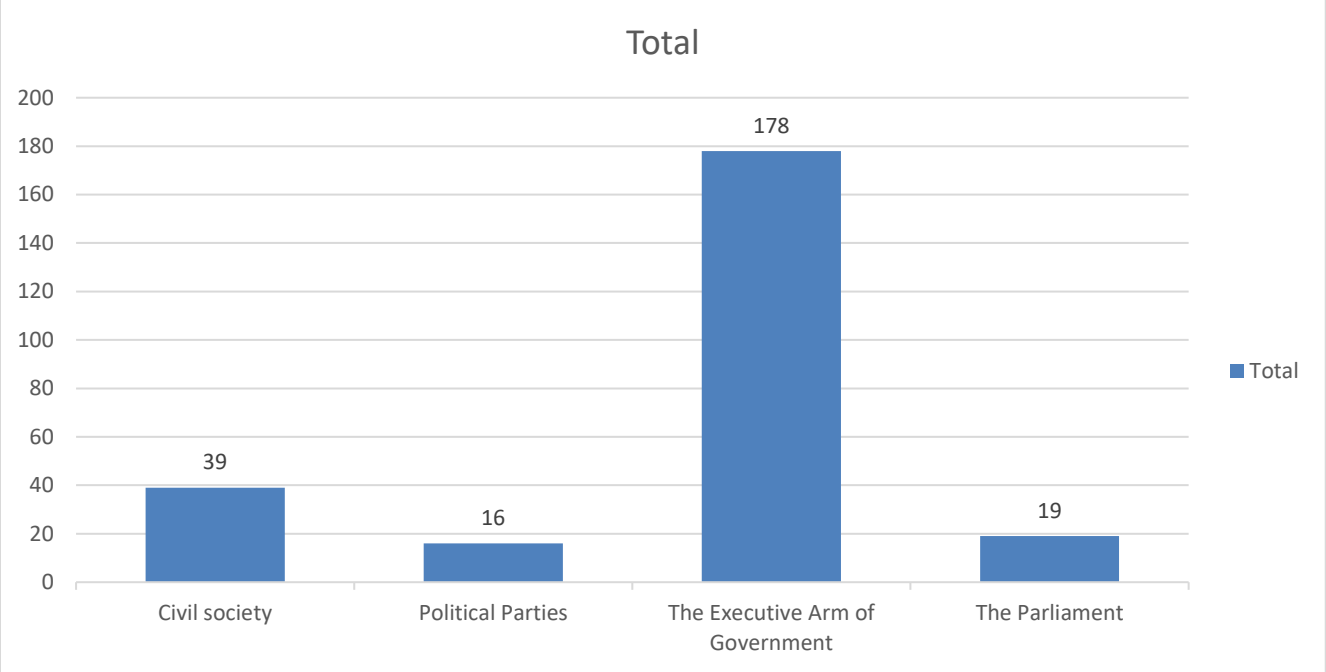
Out of a total of 431 respondents, 161 (37.4%) strongly agreed and 191 (44.3%) agreed that engaging men as partners and gender advocates is an effective strategy to promote meaningful political participation and increase women's representation in their state. Meanwhile**,** 53 respondents (12.3%) disagreed with this approach. These results indicate a strong consensus among respondents that collaborative engagement with men is a key strategy for advancing women's political involvement, highlighting the importance of inclusive advocacy and collective action in achieving gender equity in political representation.

What are the benefits for promoting meaningful political participation of female's in legislative Politics in your state?



Respondents were asked to identify the benefits of promoting meaningful political participation of women in legislative politics in their state, selecting all options that applied. Out of a total of 1,706 selections, the most frequently cited benefit was “Expands the pool of women willing to run for office” (306 responses), followed closely by “Increases public trust in the political system” (305 responses). Other notable benefits included “Promotes better understanding of gender equality issues in society” (299 responses), “Impacts the policy agenda” (268 responses), and “Improves the image and credibility of institutions” (245 responses). These results suggest that respondents recognize multiple, complementary benefits of women’s legislative participation, with a strong emphasis on representation, trust, and societal understanding of gender equality.

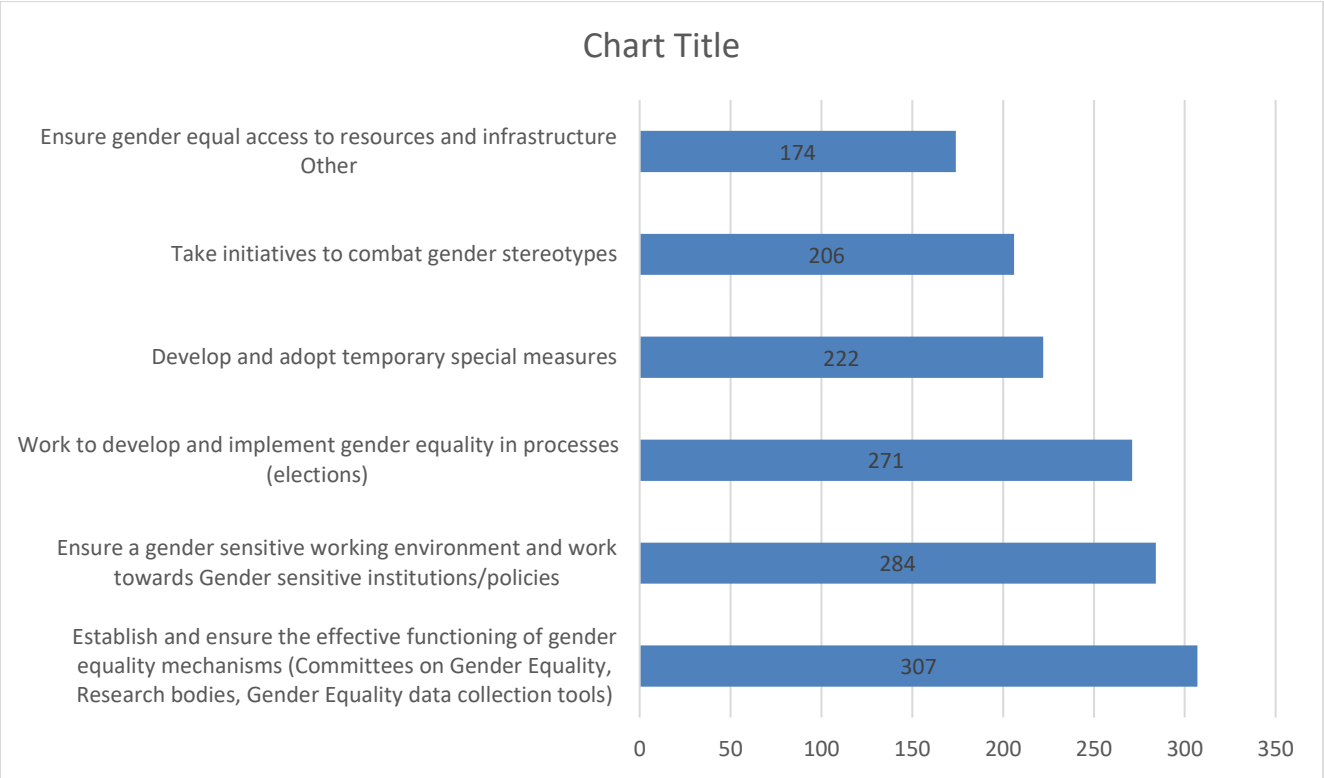
Who are the key stakeholder's in Nigeria that have positively impacted promoting female representation and meaningful participation in governance and politics?



Out of a total of 431 respondents, the majority identified the executive arm of government as the key stakeholder positively impacting the promotion of female representation and meaningful participation in governance and politics, with 178 respondents indicating this option. Other stakeholders recognized include civil society organizations (39 respondents), the parliament (19 respondents), and political parties (16 respondents).

These results suggest that respondents perceive the executive branch as the most influential in advancing gender inclusion in political processes, followed by civil society, while legislative bodies and political parties are seen as playing smaller, though still important, roles. This distribution highlights the multi-actor environment in Nigeria, where formal governmental institutions and non-governmental organizations collectively contribute to enhancing female political engagement.

Strategies the GOVERNMENT AND/OR PARLIAMENT'S AND/OR LOCAL COUNCIL'S should apply to effectively promote meaningful female political participation and increase representation in your state?



The results indicate a strong preference for institutional and policy-driven interventions to promote female representation and participation.

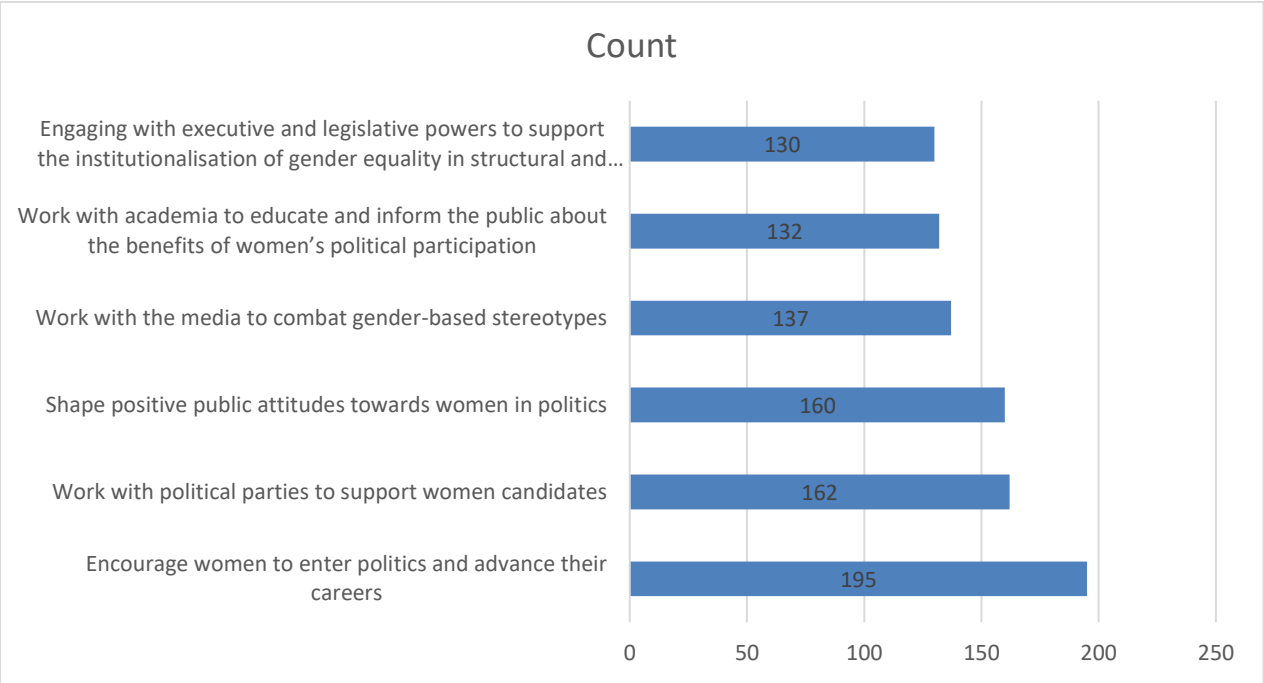
The most frequently selected response was establishing and ensuring the effective functioning of relevant institutions (307 selections), highlighting the importance respondents place on strong institutional frameworks. This was closely followed by ensuring a gender-sensitive working environment (284 selections) and developing and implementing gender equality policies (271 selections), underscoring broad support for systemic reforms within governance structures.

A substantial number of respondents also emphasized temporary special measures, such as quotas or affirmative action (222 selections), as well as initiatives to combat gender stereotypes (206 selections), reflecting recognition of both structural and socio-cultural barriers to women’s participation. Fewer respondents selected ensuring gender-equal access to resources and institutions (174

selections), while only a small minority proposed other approaches (10 selections), suggesting that the listed strategies largely capture respondents' priorities.

Overall, the pattern shows that respondents favor formal, institutional mechanisms complemented by targeted social interventions as the most effective means of advancing women's meaningful participation in governance and politics.

In your opinion which strategies should CIVIL SOCIETY apply to effectively promote meaningful female political participation and increase representation in Nigeria?



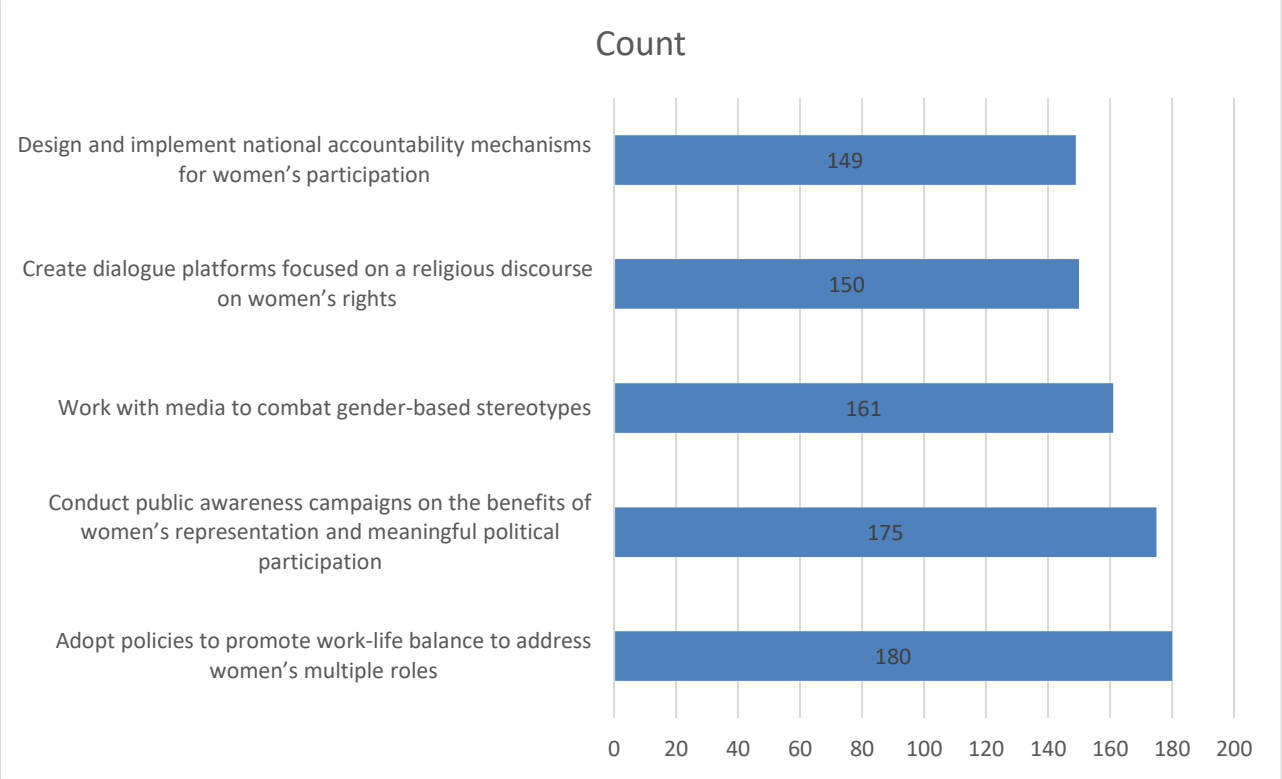
The findings indicate that respondents place the greatest emphasis on direct encouragement and support for women's political participation. The most frequently selected strategy was encouraging women to enter politics and advance their political careers (195 selections), suggesting that motivation, mentorship, and capacity-building are viewed as critical entry points.

This was followed by collaboration with political parties to support women candidates (162 selections) and efforts to shape positive public attitudes toward women in leadership (160 selections), highlighting the importance of both institutional backing and societal acceptance. A notable proportion of respondents also emphasized engagement with the media to combat gender-based stereotypes (137 selections) and partnerships with academic institutions to educate and inform the public (132 selections), reflecting recognition of the role of information, research, and public discourse in driving change.

The least frequently selected, though still significant, approach involved engagement with executive and legislative powers (130 selections), indicating that while formal government engagement is important, respondents may perceive grassroots, party-based, and societal interventions as more immediate or impactful.

Overall, the distribution suggests a balanced strategy that combines individual empowerment, institutional collaboration, and societal attitude change as key pathways for advancing women's participation and leadership in politics.

In your opinion which strategies should be implemented by OTHER STAKEHOLDER'S to combat social-cultural barriers to meaningful political participation of women and increase representation in your country?



The table shows that respondents place the greatest emphasis on policy and societal interventions that address structural and cultural barriers to women's participation. The most frequently selected strategy was adopting policies that promote work–life balance (180 selections), indicating strong recognition of the role that family responsibilities and workplace flexibility play in enabling women's engagement in public life.

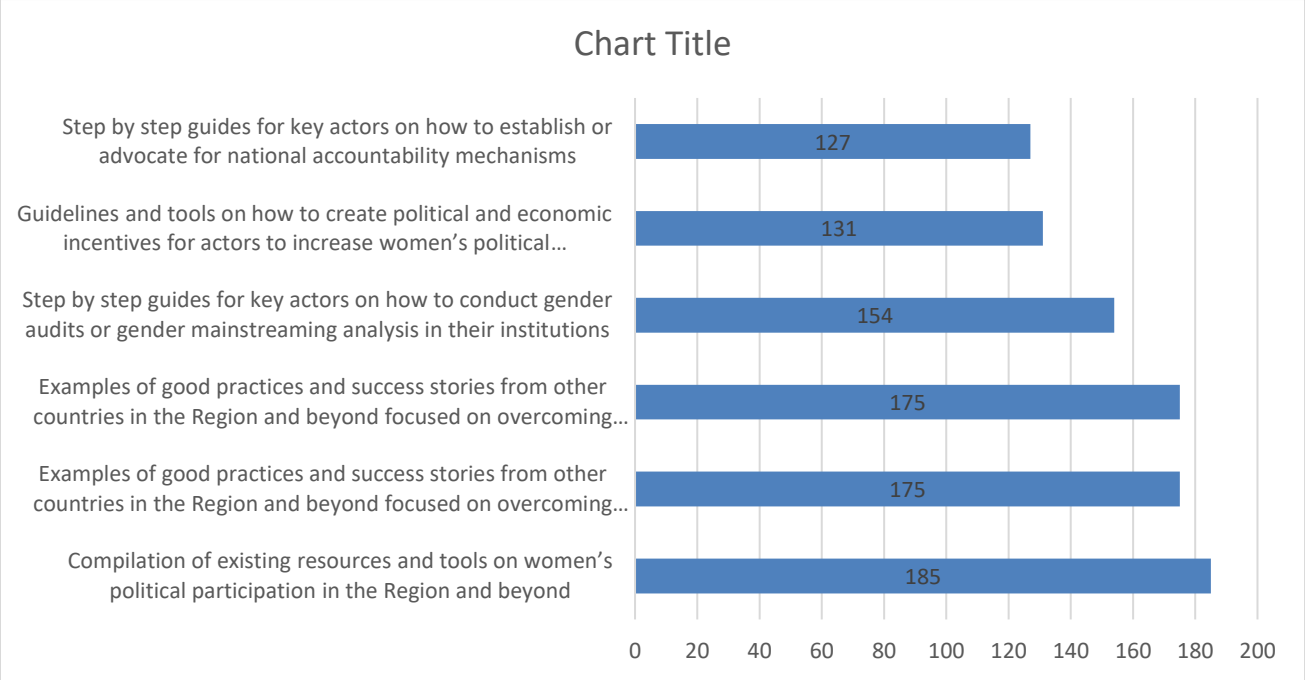
This was closely followed by public awareness campaigns highlighting the benefits of women's participation (175 selections), reflecting the perceived importance of changing societal perceptions and building broad-based support. A substantial

number of respondents also prioritized working with the media to combat gender-based stereotypes (161 selections), underscoring the influential role of media narratives in shaping public attitudes.

Slightly fewer respondents selected creating dialogue platforms focused on religious and cultural contexts (150 selections) and designing and implementing national accountability mechanisms (149 selections). While these approaches were less frequently cited, they still represent significant support for inclusive dialogue and institutional oversight as part of a comprehensive strategy.

Overall, the distribution suggests that respondents favor a combination of supportive policies, awareness-raising, and media engagement, complemented by dialogue and accountability measures, to advance women’s meaningful participation in governance and public life.

In your opinion which TOOL'S and RESOURCE'S would be helpful to support the work and efforts to promote meaningful female political participation and representation?



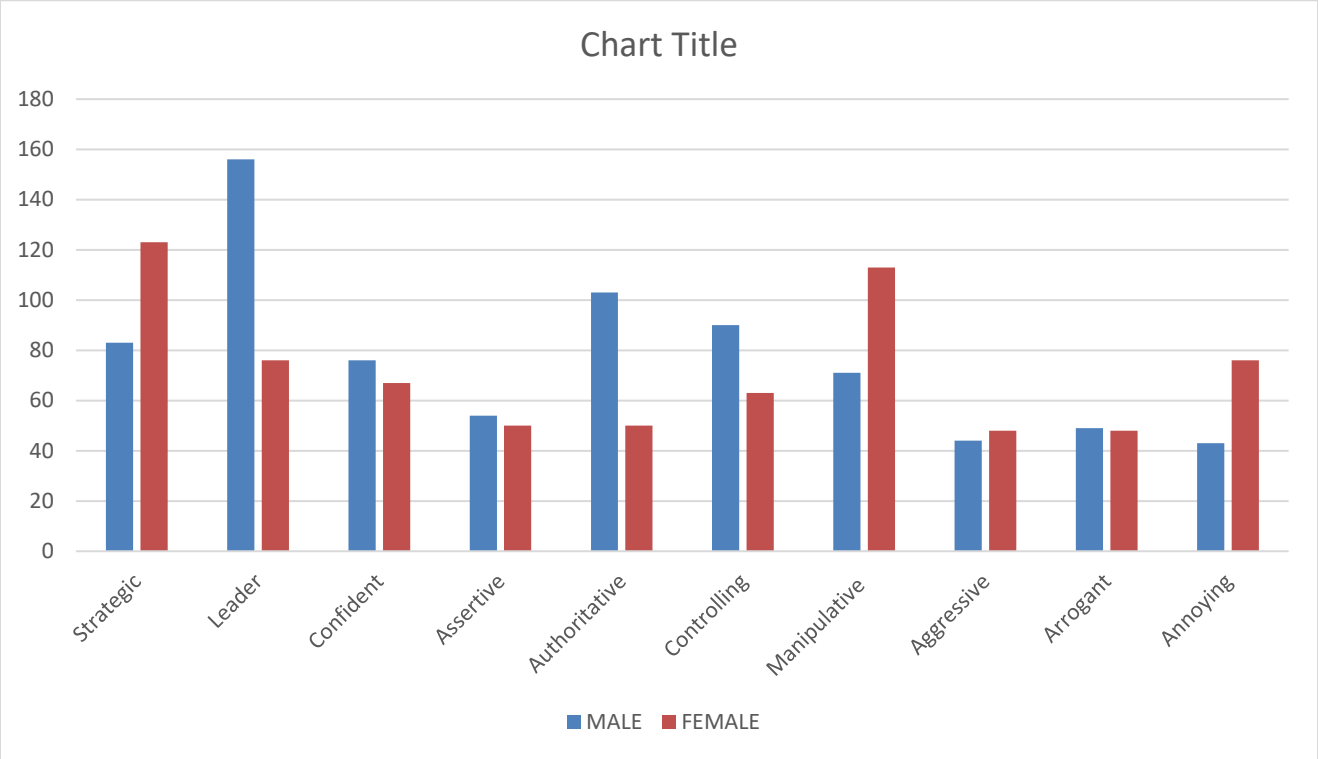
The table reflects respondents' strong preference for practical, knowledge-based support tools to advance women's participation in governance and politics. The most frequently selected option was the compilation of existing resources and tools (185 selections), indicating a clear demand for centralized, accessible materials that stakeholders can readily use rather than duplicating efforts.

Closely following this were examples of good practices and success stories (175 selections, appearing twice), underscoring the high value respondents place on learning from proven models and real-world experiences. This suggests that showcasing successful initiatives—both locally and internationally—is perceived as an effective way to inspire replication and adaptation.

A substantial number of respondents also emphasized the need for step-by-step guides for key actors (154 selections), reflecting demand for clear, operational guidance that translates policy commitments into concrete action. Slightly fewer respondents prioritized guidelines and tools for creating political strategies (131 selections) and step-by-step guides focused on implementation and execution (127 selections), though these still represent significant interest in structured and actionable frameworks.

Overall, the pattern indicates that respondents favor practical, applied resources over abstract policy statements, with particular emphasis on consolidated tools, real-life examples, and clear guidance for implementation. This highlights a strong appetite for capacity-building materials that are immediately usable by policymakers, civil society actors, and political institutions.

Male Behavioral Trait Descriptions versus Descriptions of Female behavior, in mirrored circumstances



The combined analysis reveals clear gendered differences in how leadership traits are perceived, despite substantial overlap in the types of attributes assigned to both men and women.

Female leaders are most strongly associated with strategic thinking (123 selections), followed by manipulativeness (113 selections), and leadership capability (76 selections). In contrast, male leaders are most strongly associated with leadership (156 selections) and authoritativeness (103 selections), followed by controlling behavior (90 selections) and strategic ability (83 selections).

Across both genders, traits such as aggressiveness and arrogance appear at similar, lower levels, indicating that overtly negative traits are recognized for both men and women.